



The price of negligence: 21 lives lost in Malviya Nagar hotel fire

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

At 8:30 on a quiet Wednesday morning, a narrow street in Malviya Nagar's Hauz Rani was suddenly engulfed in flames. Fire swept through the Flourish Stay B&B, a five-storey building squeezed between tangled wires and crowded concrete. When the smoke finally cleared, at least 21 people had died. Many were foreigners who had come to India not for tourism but to help sick family members at the nearby Max Hospital.

The building was allowed only six rooms under Delhi's bed-and-breakfast policy, but it was operating 25 rooms, including some in the base-

ment. There was just one entrance and one exit. The fire safety certificate is being investigated. Police described it as "an accident waiting to happen." Today, that accident happened. Rescue workers and locals went into the crowded lanes and pulled out 40 people, many suffering from smoke inhalation. Twenty-one were declared dead on arrival, and several others are in intensive care on ventila-

At Max Hospital across the road, 39 patients were brought in. Eighteen were already dead, and fifteen were in critical condition. Families waited anxiously, searching for loved ones among bodies that could not be identified right away.



Firefighters douse a fire in a hotel in New Delhi

PTI

"We can't identify them from pictures. The fire spread quickly. Thick black smoke

filled the building, and people broke windows while calling for help. A woman

holding her young child jumped from the third floor. Locals had put mattresses on

the ground to help. Both the mother and child survived, though they were injured. Mother and child survived; a local mattress seller handed out mattresses to help cushion people's falls. Others gave CPR to the injured. The basement, where many guests were trapped, was locked, and it took first responders over 20 minutes to open it. Many victims were from Central Asian and African countries. They had travelled far to help family members in hospitals but instead lost their lives in a hotel that was not properly regulated.

This fire raises serious concerns about oversight. The narrow lanes are crowded with unauthorised buildings, and overhanging electrical

wires could easily cause a fire. The so-called "bed-and-breakfast" was run like a budget hostel and was far over capacity. Officials have promised a full investigation. Police say the fire started in the ground-floor restaurant. The real problem seems to be years of ignored violations.

President Droupadi Murmu called the tragedy "extremely heartbreaking." Prime Minister Narendra Modi described it as tragic and announced ex gratia payments: 22 lakh for the families of those who died and 750,000 for the injured. Congress leaders Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi also expressed their grief and called for immediate help.

No words or compensation

can undo the loss of life. They cannot erase the memory of a mother jumping with her child or ease the pain of families searching hospital mortuary lists. Hauz Rani, close to malls and hospitals, is a crowded urban area that has faced problems for years. Today, 21 people lost their lives. Even though the fire is out, the lingering smoke reminds us that safety rules in Delhi are not always followed.

The city is left with questions. How many unsafe buildings are still hidden in these crowded lanes? For the families affected, those who tried to help, and the mother who escaped with her child, what happened in Malviya Nagar will not be forgotten.

Leaders express grief over tragic blaze

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union Home Minister Amit Shah, and Defence Minister Rajnath Singh expressed condolences on Wednesday over the deaths of 21 people in the Malviya Nagar hotel fire, with the Prime Minister announcing an ex gratia of ₹2 lakh from the Prime Minister's National Relief Fund for the next of kin of each deceased and ₹50,000 for each person injured.

President Murmu said the news of the deaths was extremely heartbreaking. "I express my deepest condolences to the bereaved families and pray for the swift recovery of those who have been injured," she said in a post on X.

Prime Minister Modi said authorities are providing all possible assistance to those affected. "The loss of lives due to a fire incident in Malviya



Nagar, Delhi, is tragic. My condolences to those who have lost their loved ones. Wishing a speedy recovery to the injured," a statement from the Prime Minister's Office said. It added that an ex gratia of ₹2 lakh from the PMNRF would be given to the next of kin of each deceased and ₹50,000 to those injured.

Home Minister Amit Shah said he was deeply grieved by the incident. "My heart is deeply grieved by the fire incident in Malviya Nagar, Delhi. The local administration is engaged in relief and rescue operations. My condolences are with those who

have lost their loved ones in this heart-wrenching tragedy. May God grant strength to the bereaved families to bear this sorrow," Shah wrote on X.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh described the incident as heart-wrenching. "The fire incident in Malviya Nagar, Delhi, is heart-wrenching. My deepest condolences to those who have lost their loved ones in this tragedy. I pray to God that He grants them the strength to bear this immense sorrow. At the same time, I wish for a speedy recovery for the injured," Singh wrote on X. Delhi Lieutenant Governor

Taranjit Singh Sandhu said he was deeply distressed. "Deeply distressed by the tragic fire at a hotel in Hauz Rani, Malviya Nagar. My thoughts and condolences are with the families of the deceased, and I join all in praying for the swift recovery of those injured," Sandhu said.

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the government is closely monitoring the situation and stands firmly with the affected families. "I pray for the speedy recovery of those injured and for strength and courage to all those affected by this heart-breaking tragedy," she said.

Death, smoke and silence: Hauz Rani wakes up to deadliest hotel fire

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

By Wednesday afternoon, the narrow lanes of Hauz Rani village had fallen eerily silent. The smell of burnt concrete and lingering smoke had replaced the usual bustle of patients' attendants, shopkeepers and hotel guests.

Residents stood in clusters, speaking in hushed tones about the tragedy that had unfolded just hours earlier at Flourish Stay B&B, where at least 21 people were killed and several others injured in a devastating fire. Several foreign nationals from Central Asia and Africa, along with a few Indians, lost their lives. Around 10 police personnel sustained injuries.

The blaze broke out around 8.50 am at the five-storey hotel, located in a congested lane of South Delhi's Malviya Nagar area. The building, which allegedly had four to five rooms on each floor and a restaurant in its basement, had only a single entry and exit route. Soon after the fire erupted, thick black smoke engulfed the structure, trapping dozens inside.

Firefighters, disaster response teams, police personnel and ambulance services descended on the locality as a massive rescue operation unfolded after the Delhi Fire Service received a distress call.

Just a day earlier, Flourish Stay had appeared like any other budget accommodation. With a 4.1-star rating on Google, it was a preferred option for relatives and patients undergoing treatment at local hospitals. On Wednesday, however, the building stood blackened and gutted, its windows shattered and walls charred.

"It was a major accident. Nothing appears to have survived inside," said a member of the forensic team examining the site. "We are collecting evidence to determine how the fire spread."

Residents described scenes of panic and desperation as locals, police personnel, and



Police and firefighters at the scene following a fire in a five-story building in south Delhi's Malviya Nagar area, Wednesday

PANKAJ KUMAR

emergency responders struggled to save those trapped inside.

Shahid, who runs a mobile repair shop opposite the hotel, said he was asleep when the fire broke out. "I was called and rushed here. Had the fire brigade arrived earlier, perhaps the damage would not have been this extensive," he said.

Abdul Karim, a resident of Hauz Rani village, recalled seeing police officers risking their lives to save trapped occupants.

"The smoke was choking. A local police officer used a hammer and stones to break windows so people could escape. His hands were burned in the process. I saw a woman and a child jump from a window. The child allegedly got entangled in electric wires," Karim said. He added that the hotel's location in a cramped neighbourhood with narrow lanes and limited ventilation may have worsened the situation.

A few metres away, Shoaib, who lives about 100 metres from the hotel, said: "When we reached around 8.45 am, we brought mattresses and blankets from a nearby shop to help people jump from the building. Most of the guests we saw appeared to be foreigners. A piece of broken glass pierced my foot while helping with the rescue," he said.

Sanjay Goyal, who owns a grocery store nearby, said the suffocating smoke was visible across the locality. "Along with a beat constable, locals broke glass windows using stones to rescue

people. My hands were slightly burnt. The smoke was unbearable," he said.

Questions are also being raised about the hotel's safety measures. *The Pioneer* visited another branch of Flourish Inn, just walking distance from the now-gutted building. A woman from Nepal, whose relative is being treated at Max Hospital, said hotel staff at another branch of Flourish Inn had suggested she move to the affected property just four to five days ago.

"Thankfully, I did not shift," she said. The woman and her relative occupied a room with a small kitchen on the building's terrace. "We can cook our meals in this kitchen, as well," she said.

Additionally, we did not find any staff members or hotel officials at this Flourish Inn branch. This branch also has a single entry and exit point, and a basement.

Locals also told *The Pioneer* that Lovkesh Bajaj, the owner of Flourish Inn, operates several other guesthouses and hotel properties in the Hauz Rani-Malviya Nagar area. Police have registered an FIR under charges of culpable homicide not amounting to murder and are investigating alleged safety violations at the property. The owner remains at large.

Doctors treating the injured said smoke inhalation likely caused many of the fatalities. Dr Sandeep Budhiraja, Group Medical Director at Max Healthcare, explained that toxic gases generated during fires often prove deadlier than flames.

LG Sandhu orders magisterial inquiry after tragedy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Home Minister Ashish Sood chaired an emergency high-level meeting on Wednesday following the Malviya Nagar fire tragedy and ordered a magisterial inquiry to probe the incident and fix responsibility, while launching a one-month city-wide enforcement drive against fire safety violations beginning Thursday across all hotels, lodges, nursing homes, coaching institutes, and restaurants.

The meeting was attended by the Chief Secretary, Commissioner MCD, Principal Secretary Home, Secretary Tourism, Secretary Health and Family Welfare, Principal Director of Delhi

Fire Service, and Special CEO of DDMA. A comprehensive multi-departmental action plan was drawn up covering enforcement, prevention, and immediate relief for those affected by Wednesday's blaze.

The magisterial inquiry has been ordered under the area of the District Magistrate with defined terms of reference to establish what happened at the Flourish Stay facility in Hauz Rani and who bears responsibility for the deaths of 21 people.

On enforcement, the meeting decided that a massive one-month drive beginning June 4 will check compliance with fire safety norms across all hotels, lodges, inns, nursing homes, coaching institutes, restaurants, and other vulnerable commercial establishments.

Owner of ill-fated inn detained

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lovkesh Bajaj, owner of the Flourish Inn, Malviya Nagar, has been arrested by Delhi Police on Wednesday night in connection with the blaze that claimed 21 lives. Bajaj's arrest came hours after authorities issued a lookout notice against him when he remained untraceable following the tragedy. Additionally, the police had filed an FIR in a culpable homicide not amounting to murder.

The fire killed 21 people, including 17 foreign nationals, and triggered a probe into the circumstances surrounding the operation of the five-storey guesthouse and possible violations of safety norms.

On the morning of 3 June 2026, a major fire broke out at the property. It was reported at around 8:48 am. The fire may have started in the basement kitchen due to a suspected cylinder blast or a short circuit.

The hotel was licensed under the Bed & Breakfast scheme (registered in 2024, valid until 2027) for only six rooms, but it was alleged-



Lovkesh Bajaj

ly operating 20-25 rooms, including illegal additions and basement use. It lacked a valid fire NOC (No Objection Certificate), had only one narrow entry/exit, sealed windows, and other safety violations (e.g., electronic locks that jammed).

Bajaj and his three business partners also reportedly own at least three hotels or guest houses within a 100-metre radius (and several more across Delhi), many of which similarly lacked proper licences and fire safety documents.

Delhi Police registered an FIR at Malviya Nagar Police Station against Bajaj. The charges were under culpable homicide not amounting to murder and other Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita sec-



Hotels and lodges operating more rooms than permitted under their licences will have the excess rooms sealed and closed. Non-complying premises will be shut down. Strict sealing and legal action will be taken against defaulters.

The Home Department, Government of NCT of Delhi, has been designated as the

nodal department to lead the campaign, with all other relevant departments required to collaborate. The Chief Secretary and the Police Commissioner will jointly monitor the exercise for the next month.

At the ground level, the District Magistrate, Deputy Commissioner of Police, Deputy Commissioner MCD,

Malviya Nagar hotel had no fire clearance

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The hotel that caught fire in Delhi's Malviya Nagar on Wednesday, killing at least 21 people, had never received a fire safety clearance, and was operating approximately 25 rooms against a permitted six.

The additional floors had been added without informing authorities, and it stood more than 15 metres high, making a fire NOC mandatory. Apart from that, it had only one entry and exit point: a combination of violations that investigators say turned the building into a death trap before the first flame appeared.

Officials said the deceased included 11 foreign nationals. At least 19 of the 35 injured remain in critical condition in Delhi hospitals. Police have registered an FIR under culpable homicide charges and other relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. The building owner, identified as Lavkesh Bajaj, and his wife have absconded, and police suspect they fled in a Mercedes car. Authorities



have issued alerts to railway stations and airports to prevent them from fleeing. Police teams found the Saket residence locked.

Investigators have identified three partners who ran the hotel and reportedly own several other hotels and guesthouses across Delhi. The tourism department licence was in the name of Jai Mishra.

Deputy Chief Fire Officer A K Malik confirmed that the fire department had never received a fire NOC application for the building. "As far as a fire NOC is concerned, we had not received any reference from either the building authorities or the licensing agency," he said.

Residents say fire tenders arrived late at Malviya Nagar; Delhi Fire Service denies

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Residents and eyewitnesses near the Malviya Nagar hotel fire site alleged on Wednesday that fire tenders arrived late at the scene, claiming lives could have been saved with a quicker response, even as the Delhi Fire Service rejected the charge. Meanwhile, ten Delhi Police personnel who rushed into the burning building without protective gear to rescue trapped occupants were hospitalised with injuries, all sent to AIIMS, where their condition is reported as stable.

Anjum, who owns a building directly opposite the gutted structure, said she first sensed something was wrong when she went to her father's room early in the morning to give him his medicine. "We smelled something, but thought it might be something else. Then a spark occurred, and the building soon caught fire. Fire brigades were called around 8 am, but they arrived late. If they could have



Police cordon off the area after a fire broke out at a bed-and-breakfast in a five-storey building in south Delhi's Malviya Nagar area on Wednesday. PTI

come earlier, casualties could have been prevented," she said.

She described the scenes she witnessed from across the lane. Many occupants had suffered severe burn injuries. Others had no option but to jump. "People were very badly injured and burned. People saved themselves by jumping from the building," she said.

Another resident said the neigh-

bourhood had to organise its own rescue before emergency teams arrived.

"People from nearby buildings tried to rescue those trapped using ropes and provided mattresses so they could jump out of the building immediately," he said. He added that the heat and smoke were so intense outside the building that residents of neighbouring structures could not remain inside their own

homes. "If the impact outside was so severe, how could the people trapped inside survive?" he asked.

The Delhi Fire Service officer on duty rejected the allegation of delayed response. "We received a call at 8:50 am and immediately rushed seven vehicles to the spot. The rescue operation was also carried out without delay. There was no delay from the fire department," the officer said.

The ten police personnel who were injured have been identified as Head Constables Kartar, 32; Hargyan, 40; Prem Chand, 40; Jitendra, 40; and Dinesh, 35; and Constables Vikram, 34; Deepak, 38; Rampal, 30; Sandeep, 30; and Raviranjana, 26.

A senior police officer described what the personnel did when they reached the building. "Without thinking even for a moment, police personnel launched an immediate rescue. Our teams rushed to the spot after the PCR call was received," the officer said. All ten injured personnel were rushed to AIIMS for treatment, and their condition is stable, police said.

Recurring fire tragedies highlight safety failures in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The fire tragedy on Wednesday has once again brought out a stark point that the national capital has not learned lessons from the past incidents. They include the devastating Uphaar cinema which claimed 59 innocent lives in 1997, 43 in 2019 Anaj Mandi blaze and 27 in 2022 Mundka tragedy. These incidents indicate a recurring pattern — negligence, safety violations and missed warnings.

As Delhi continues to witness deadly blazes, the pattern of tragedies that leave several families grieving for years has remained strikingly similar — people trapped inside buildings, narrow access routes hampering rescue efforts, and allegations of inadequate safety measures.



A boy looks out from balcony after a fire broke out at five-storey building in Delhi's Malviya Nagar. PTI

The deadliest reminder remains the 1997 Uphaar Cinema fire in Green Park, where a blaze triggered by a transformer malfunction during the screening of the film "Border" killed 59 people and injured more than 100. Investigations later found serious safety lapses, including blocked exits.

More than two decades later, in December 2019, a fire ripped through an illegal manufacturing unit in the congested Anaj Mandi area, killing 43

workers who were asleep inside the building. The structure lacked proper fire clearances and emergency exits, while narrow lanes delayed rescue operations. Many suffocated to death after getting trapped inside the smoke-filled premises.

Before the Anaj Mandi tragedy, 14 people died in a tent fire during a religious congregation in Nand Nagri in 2011. Seventeen people lost their lives in a blaze at an illegal firecracker and packaging unit in Bawana in January 2018. A year later, 17 guests lost their lives in a fire at a hotel in Karol Bagh, where investigators found violations linked to an illegally constructed kitchen.

According to Delhi Fire Service data, the city recorded 1,396 fire-related calls in January 2026, during which six people lost their lives in fire incidents.

BJP blames previous governments for illegal hotels after Delhi blaze

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi BJP president and Member of Parliament Harsh Malhotra on Wednesday blamed successive Delhi governments for the proliferation of allegedly illegal hotels in the Capital, following the devastating fire at a hotel in Hauz Rani that claimed 21 lives.

Expressing grief over the tragedy, Malhotra alleged that numerous hotels had been allowed to operate on the basis of incomplete licences due to a nexus between hoteliers and previous Congress and Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) governments. He claimed that the current state of the hotel sector was the result of "27 years of corruption" between 1998 and 2024.

Referring to the gutted hotel, Malhotra said a bed-and-breakfast licence issued for only six rooms in 2024 was allegedly used to run a hotel across the entire building.



He further alleged that the establishment obtained high-load electricity connections despite deficiencies in regulatory clearances and that mandatory fire safety norms were not properly verified.

The BJP leader also criticised senior AAP leader Saurabh Bharadwaj for making political statements on the incident, alleging that the Tourism Department had granted an incomplete licence to the hotel during Bharadwaj's tenure as a minister in May 2024. He demanded an explanation for the alleged lapse.

Meanwhile, Delhi government minister Ashish Sood and local MLA Satish Upadhyay visited the affected area on Wednesday morning. Based on their assessment, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta ordered an immediate inspection of hotels, motels and similar establishments across Delhi.

According to Malhotra, establishments found violating prescribed norms will face immediate action, including disconnection of electricity supply and closure. An inspection drive is expected to begin shortly.

Sealed windows, no fire NOC: Safety lapses turn Malviya Nagar hotel blaze deadly

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

When the fire broke out, the glass windows were sealed, and the sensor-operated gates stopped working. The hotel in Malviya Nagar was overcrowded and failed to comply with fire safety rules, worsening the situation. Many people inside had no way to escape as smoke and flames spread quickly through the building. At least 21 people died in the fire, including six foreigners. Officials said the number could go up because nine people are still in critical condition. Fire officials said the five-storey building was licensed only as a bed-and-breakfast for six rooms. However, they believe it actually had about 25 rooms spread across the basement, ground floor, and upper floors. They also said the building did not have a fire No Objection Certificate (NOC).

Chief Fire Officer Abhilash Kumar Malik explained that the building had a basement,



Forensic officials at the site after a fire broke out at a bed-and-breakfast in a five-storey building in south Delhi's Malviya Nagar area. PTI

Residents said the sensor-operated entrance gate stopped working after the fire started. The permanently sealed windows kept people from escaping or getting fresh air. Sheikh Ali, who lives there, said the building is six years old and has more than 25 rooms, including some in the basement. "The fire locked the doors, and someone had permanently sealed the windows. As a result, people inside could not escape for a long time," he said.

Residents said that local people used stones and hammers to break the windows and the main gate to help those trapped inside. After the windows were broken, several people jumped from the upper floors to escape.

Another resident, Asif, said the fire extinguishers in the building were too small to handle such a big fire. He said people first noticed the fire between 8 and 8:30 in the morning, but by then it had already spread widely.

He explained that there was a blast in an electrical plug after someone switched off a kitchen appliance. People tried to put out the fire with extinguishers, but the flames spread quickly.

"Within five minutes, the ground floor filled with thick smoke. In another six to seven minutes, the fire had spread to the upper floors. Several people broke window panes on the second floor and jumped to save themselves," the eyewitness said.

B&B inferno claims 21 lives in Delhi

Max Hospital received 39 patients from the site. Eighteen were brought dead, while 15 were admitted to the intensive care unit, including eight on ventilator support. Five persons with minor injuries were treated and discharged, while one patient with extensive burns was shifted to Safdarjung Hospital. Doctors said the victims suffered from smoke inhalation, burns and injuries sustained while attempting to escape.

The All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) treated 13 others, including three people injured after jumping from the building and 10 police personnel who sustained injuries during evacuation efforts.

Delhi Fire Services Chief AK Malik said the building had been thoroughly searched and the fire completely extinguished. The exact cause remains under investigation, though preliminary indications point to either an electrical short circuit or a cylinder-related incident in the restaurant area.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta expressed grief over the loss of lives and said multiple emergency agencies were mobilised immediately after information about the fire was received. In a social media post, she said teams from the Delhi Fire Services, Delhi Police, District Disaster Management Authority, CATS Ambulance Services and other agencies launched rescue and relief operations without delay.

"Their swift response helped in rescuing and evacuating several persons from the affected premises," Gupta said, adding that the Delhi Government is closely monitoring the situation and ensuring all necessary medical assistance and support to affected families.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi expressed condolences and announced an ex gratia of 2 lakh rupees from the Prime Minister's National Relief Fund for the next of kin of each deceased and 50,000 rupees for the injured. President Droupadi Murmu described the incident as "extremely heartbreaking" and prayed for the speedy recovery of those injured. Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi also expressed condolences and called for adequate compensation and medical care for the victims.

Smoke, panic and a leap for survival

Residents said people from the neighbourhood sprang into action as soon as the fire broke out, with many joining rescue efforts and helping evacuate those trapped inside.

As thick black smoke billowed out of the windows and flames rapidly spread through the building, panic-stricken occupants were seen

smashing window panes, leaning out of openings and desperately calling for help. With stairways and internal passages choked by smoke, several guests appeared to have no option but to jump from the upper floors.

Eyewitnesses said at least six people jumped from various floors of the building in a bid to escape the inferno. Among them was a woman carrying a young child in her arms.

"There was chaos everywhere. People were trapped and shouting for help from the windows. Some broke open the glass panes and climbed out. We saw several people jumping from different floors," said a local resident who joined the rescue effort.

The scary scenes prompted residents and shopkeepers in the area to act before emergency services could fully reach the spot. Mattress shop owners and other locals quickly brought mattresses and blankets onto the narrow road below the building, arranging them side by side to cushion the fall of those attempting to escape. "The woman was holding the child tightly when she jumped. A few others also jumped shortly before and after her. People below kept repositioning the mattresses wherever someone appeared ready to leap," another eyewitness said.

Several residents formed human chains, gave instructions to those trapped inside and guided them towards windows from where they could be rescued or make the jump safely. Many people were also seen shouting at people to stop recording videos and help in the rescue efforts.

The sight of people emerging through smoke-filled windows and hurling themselves towards mattresses laid out by residents unfolded before hundreds gathered in the area. Many survivors were seen being carried away by locals and rushed to nearby hospitals. Mohd Sahidul Islam, Aarmin Jaman, Riyana were identified to be among those who jumped to escape the fire.

Revolt rocks TMC as Speaker backs dissidents

Sources indicate that the expelled MLA's elevation to the opposition bench is being viewed by the dissidents as a symbolic assertion of their strength and a direct rebuke to the current TMC dispensation.

A former Left Front leader who crossed over to the TMC in 2018, Ritabrata Banerjee's journey from ideological opponent to party insider, and now apparent rebel, has been anything but conventional. His sudden expulsion had initially appeared to isolate him politically. Still, the swift mobilisation of nearly 60 MLAs in his favour suggests that discontent within the TMC ranks runs far deeper than the party leadership may have anticipated.

By recognising Banerjee as LoP, the Speaker has effectively acknowledged the numerical

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strength of the rebel group, granting them official status and the associated privileges in the Assembly. This includes dedicated seating, speaking rights, and the institutional heft that comes with the position, tools that the dissidents are likely to use to amplify their voice against the ruling establishment.

Political observers note that the move raises critical questions about the TMC's unity, which has long projected an image of monolithic loyalty under Mamata Banerjee. The fact that a recently expelled leader could muster support from over a quarter of the party's MLAs points to simmering grievances, possibly over ticket distribution, organisational decisions, or internal power dynamics.

Yet Banerjee himself has been careful not to burn bridges completely. His insistence that "Mamata Banerjee is our leader" appears to be a calibrated attempt to frame the rebellion not as a full-scale split but as an internal correction - a claim that the "real" TMC spirit now resides with the dissident group.

Whether this development marks the beginning of a larger fracture within the TMC or remains a contained episode of legislative manoeuvring will depend on how the party high command responds in the coming days. For now, however, Ritabrata Banerjee occupies the opposition's chair, holding the keys - both literally and figuratively - to what could become one of the most intriguing chapters in West Bengal's recent political history.

Shivakumar takes charge as Karnataka CM

Shivakumar, a 64-year-old Vokkaliga strongman, was elected leader of the Congress Legislature Party on May 30, following Siddaramaiah's resignation as the chief minister on May 28. Shivakumar had served as deputy chief minister under Siddaramaiah.

AICC general secretaries KC Venugopal and Randeep Singh Surjewala, CMs of Congress ruled states, several top Congress leaders, dignitaries, and invitees were present at the swearing-in. Religious leaders from all major communities were also present.

According to officials, the invitees included students from a Government school in Doddalaahalli in Kanakapura, which is Shivakumar's native village. Representatives from various sections of society, including labourers, civic workers, farmer leaders, women self-help groups, and pro-Kannada organisations took part.

Rahul congratulated Shivakumar and the new council of ministers in Karnataka, saying people's trust in the Congress remains its greatest responsibility. The guarantees of Congress remain the foundations for governance and commitment to social justice, he said, assuring people

that they will deliver. He also thanked former chief minister Siddaramaiah for his leadership and service, which "strengthened Karnataka and improved millions of lives".

The first challenge of Shivakumar was to carefully address cabinet formation and portfolio allocation. In the new cabinet, he will have to strike a balance by ensuring representation while keeping caste equations, regions, and Siddaramaiah loyalists in mind.

Keeping the AHINDA vote bank with Congress will be one of the key tasks for the Vokkaliga strongman Shivakumar, now that Siddaramaiah has stepped down as chief minister.

The strong consolidation of AHINDA (Kannada acronym for minorities, backward classes and Dalits) votes in favour of Congress, with Siddaramaiah considered a strong proponent of these communities' at the helm, helped Congress come to power in 2023. Their support remains crucial for the party in future polls.

To manage this, Shivakumar must work by taking Siddaramaiah and his supporters into confidence while also continuing to remain on good terms with dominant communities.

Shivakumar will have to ensure that the other numerically large dominant community in the state, the Veerashiva-Lingayats' spread over large parts of north Karnataka and in some pockets of the south' are not antagonised by any of his decisions. The test of how Shivakumar will manage various communities will come when the report on the social and educational survey, popularly known as the "caste census," is out.

Various communities, especially the dominant Lingayats and Vokkaligas had strong objections to the earlier survey report and Shivakumar himself had expressed reservations.

To clean air, Union Cabinet approves...

Government vehicles are excluded from the scheme. The Government said that by accelerating the transition to cleaner transport technologies, the scheme is expected to significantly reduce vehicular emissions and contribute to improved air quality across the Delhi-NCR region.

Implementation will be fully digital through an integrated portal, which will enable real-time eligibility checks, automated interest subvention claims, monthly fuel voucher credits, and monitoring of pollution reduction outcomes.

The Union Government benefits will continue for five years from the date of registration of the new vehicle, ensuring sustained impact beyond the two-year enrolment window.

The scheme will be monitored by an Empowered Committee, chaired by cabinet secretary with CEO, Niti Aayog, secretaries of MOHUA, MoRT&H, MoPNG, DFS, chief secretaries of states in Delhi NCR as members, and member

secretary of NCRPB being the member convenor.

As per the report on "Source Apportionment of Particulate Matter (PM 2.5 and PM 10) in the NCR" prepared by the Automotive Research Association of India (ARAI) and The Energy and Resources Institute (TERI), published in August 2018, the transport sector contributes 14% of PM 2.5, 40% of Carbon Monoxide (CO), and 63% of Nitrogen Oxide (NOx) emissions in the Delhi-NCR. Within the transport sector, trucks and buses account for 36% of PM 2.5 emissions with only 3% of the total fleet. It is estimated that a single Pre-BIS heavy-duty vehicle emits as much as 14 BS-VI compliant vehicles. Even a BS-IV vehicle emits 2.7 times more than a BS-VI counterpart. Hence, the newer fleet is expected to reduce the vehicular pollution substantially.

The Cabinet approval comes as policymakers continue to explore measures to curb transport-related emissions in Delhi-NCR, where deteriorating air quality remains one of the region's most persistent environmental challenges. Officials expect the replacement of older diesel fleets with cleaner BS-VI and electric alternatives to contribute significantly to lowering emissions from the commercial transport sector.

Indian killed in Iranian strike on Kuwait

"We offer our deepest condolences to the bereaved family. Our Embassy is extending all possible assistance to those injured. We remain in close contact with local authorities for the welfare of Indian nationals. Indian Missions and Posts across the region are on alert and continue to proactively support our community."

In a post on social media, the Embassy of India in Kuwait posted on X, "Embassy of India in Kuwait expresses its deepest condolences at the tragic demise of an Indian national due to an attack on the airport in Kuwait today. The Embassy is in touch with the bereaved family and is closely coordinating with the Kuwaiti authorities to render all."

Earlier, on March 30, another Indian national was killed in Kuwait in Iranian strikes on a power and water desalination plant.

Kuwait, meanwhile, suspended air traffic on Wednesday after the Iranian strikes, Directorate General of Civil Aviation spokesperson Abdullah Al-Rajhi was quoted as saying by the state-run KUNA news agency. Air traffic was suspended and flights were diverted to nearby airports until further notice, he said.

Dr Abdullah Al-Sund, the official spokesperson for the Ministry of Health, said that seven hospitals have received 63 injured so far following the attack targeting the airport. He added that seven cases have undergone urgent major surgical procedures, in addition to several minor surgeries. Abdullah said that the injured included civilians, airport workers, and travellers.

Cabinet approves ₹10,000 cr to curb ATF cost

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Providing a big succour to the embattled commercial airlines due to the ongoing West Asia conflict, the Union cabinet on Wednesday approved a ₹10,000 crore aviation turbine fuel (ATF) price stabilisation programme. It will cushion airlines from soaring fuel costs triggered by the war, a move aimed at protecting air connectivity and limiting fare volatility.

The major decision comes amid recent developments due to the conflict that have pushed up international ATF prices and increased pressure on airlines.

The scheme will provide interest-free advances of up to ₹10,000 crore to state-owned oil marketing companies (OMCs), enabling them to supply ATF to scheduled Indian airlines at a stabilised price for domestic and international operations, according to a Government statement.



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The support mechanism comes as international ATF prices have surged to about ₹142 per litre in May from ₹60.50 per litre in March, increasing financial pressure on airlines at a time when fuel accounts for nearly 40 per cent of operating costs and, in some cases, as much as 60 per cent during periods of extreme volatility.

Under the arrangement, OMCs will be compensated whenever international import parity prices exceed a benchmark level set under the approved mechanism. Any support extended to OMCs will be recovered once global fuel prices moderate, with proceeds returned to the Consolidated Fund of India through a defined true-up process.

Announcing the decision, Information and Broadcasting Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw

said the budgetary support will help airlines in the backdrop of a rise in ATF prices due to the conflict and closure of airspace by Pakistan for Indian carriers.

The prices of aviation turbine fuel, which accounts for around 40 per cent of an airline's operational costs, have surged in recent weeks in the wake of the West Asia crisis, which started in late February.

Vaishnaw said the fund would help stabilise ATF prices for scheduled Indian carriers and prevent disruption of airline operations.

With the fund, airlines would get a stable ATF price as long as the turmoil is there, and once the crisis is over, then the participating airlines would have to reimburse the amount, he said.

According to the minister, the fund would shield air passengers from fare spikes, driven by the global oil price surge, and also protect 77 lakh jobs dependent on the

aviation ecosystem. The budgetary support will be in the form of interest-free advances to OMCs through the Demands for Grants of the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, an official release said.

The support will be provided to OMCs to facilitate stable ATF pricing for airlines during the ongoing period of exceptional fuel price volatility arising from the West Asia crisis.

The corpus will compensate OMCs for losses arising from elevated international ATF prices whenever the prevailing Import Parity Price exceeds the benchmark price, determined under the approved mechanism.

"When international ATF prices moderate, the differential amount shall be recovered from OMCs and returned to the Consolidated Fund of India. The arrangement shall continue until the entire support amount is fully recovered and settled,"

it added. ATF price stabilisation support will be in force for a period of 36 months with provision for annual review or until the advance amount is fully recovered/settled, whichever is earlier.

Vaishnaw further said the fund would help safeguard public investment in airport infrastructure by keeping airline operations viable and maintaining air connectivity to Europe, North America and Central Asia amid the Pakistan airspace closure.

Indian airlines are now taking longer routes for international flights, which also means increased fuel burn due to the Pakistan airspace closure that has been in place since early last year.

While ATF price has been capped for domestic operations, Indian carriers continue to purchase the fuel for international operations at Import Parity Prices (IPP), exposing them to elevated fuel costs.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday congratulated Mette Frederiksen on assuming office as the Denmark PM for a "remarkable" third consecutive term and said he was looking forward to working closely with her to further strengthen the India-Denmark Green Strategic Partnership. In a social media post, Prime Minister Modi also said India and Denmark share an enduring partnership founded on mutual trust, shared values and a common commitment to a sustainable future. "Congratulations to my friend Mette Frederiksen on assuming office as the Prime Minister of Denmark for a remarkable third consecutive term," Modi said.

"I look forward to working closely with Prime Minister Frederiksen to further strengthen the India-Denmark Green Strategic Partnership and take our cooperation to new heights for the benefit of our peoples," he said.

(PTI)

(PTI)

Jagan demands CBI probe into 2025 Andhra teacher recruitment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

YSRCP supremo YS Jagan Mohan Reddy on Wednesday demanded a CBI probe into the 2025 teacher recruitment drive, alleging "widespread irregularities" and vowed to constitute a commission of inquiry when his party returns to power if the TDP-led coalition Government fails to act.

The Andhra Pradesh Government has recruited nearly 16,000 Government teachers through the District Selection Committee (DSC) – 2025 examination last year.



However, Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu said the recruitment process was conducted with complete transparency and strict adherence to rules.

"Reddy has demanded a CBI inquiry into the DSC-2025 recruitment process, stating that the testimonies of candidates reveal widespread irregularities, violations and lack of transparency in the conduct of the examination and selection process," said a YSRCP press release, quoting Reddy.

Several DSC candidates from across the southern State called on the former chief minister today and explained the alleged injustice they suffered in the recruitment process, "despite securing ranks, attending interviews, completing certificate verification and fulfilling all eligibility requirements."

Nearly 44,000 applications filed for re-evaluation: CBSE

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Nearly 44,000 students have availed the verification and re-evaluation facility for board exams and completed the application process till Wednesday morning, the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) has said.

The board said the online portal has received a total of 43,980 applications for verification and re-evaluation of answer sheets.

"The portal has accepted 4,924 applications for verification and 39,056 applications for re-evaluation (total of 43,980) as of 12 noon today," the CBSE said in a post on X on Wednesday.

It said payment gateways of the State Bank of India (SBI), Canara Bank, Bank of Baroda and Indian Bank are available

on the verification and re-evaluation portal, adding that students are not required to have an account with these banks to complete the payment process.

"Students need not have an account with these banks to complete payment, but can use any of these payment gateways to make payments," the board said.

"As of 9:30 am today, nearly 40,000 students have availed this facility and completed the application process successfully without any issues," it added.

Candidates may use online payment options, including UPI, net banking, credit card and debit card, through the designated gateways, it said.

"Please rely on official CBSE communications for correct information," the board added. The portal was



launched after a delay, with the CBSE having earlier said that filing applications for verification and re-evaluation of answer books was expected to begin by May 29.

The development comes following concerns raised by some students and parents over the on-screen marking (OSM) system used by the board.

The CBSE has faced criticism from students and parents over technical glitches, payment failures and access-related issues during the verification and re-evaluation process.

The board launched the online portal on Tuesday for the verification of issues observed in scanned copies of answer books and re-evaluation of answers for students dissatisfied with their Class-

12 board exam evaluation.

According to the board, the facility is available only to those students who have obtained scanned copies of their evaluated answer books.

"The portal for applying for verification of issues observed in the supplied scanned copy of the answer book and re-evaluation of answers has been made live on June 2, 2026. Students can avail the facility of verification of issue(s) observed in the supplied scanned copy of the answer book, if any, and re-evaluation of answer(s) if not satisfied with the evaluation," the CBSE said.

The portal will remain open from June 2 to June 6 (midnight), and no offline applications or requests submitted after the deadline will be accepted.

IIT-Roorkee admits JEE Advanced 2026 data glitch

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

IIT-Roorkee has confirmed that the JEE (Advanced) 2026 results portal faced a cloud storage configuration issue after a teenager who identifies as a cybersecurity researcher claimed that personal and examination details of lakhs of students were accessible without authorisation.

The response from the IIT-Roorkee, which conducted the exam this year, came after the cybersecurity researcher, 16-year-old Rylen Anil, took to X, claiming that the public cloud storage endpoint of the result portal was accessible without authentication, exposing bulk candidate data.

The institute on Tuesday night said the data stored was in read-only mode, with no possibility of record alteration and added that the issue was being addressed on priority.

The user had alleged that around 1.79 lakh result records and 1.87 lakh admit



card PDFs were accessible, along with personal details such as names, dates of birth and mobile numbers.

"JEE Advanced 2026 candidate/result infrastructure had a public cloud storage misconfiguration exposing bulk candidate data without auth. This exposed ~179.6k result records and ~187.3k admit-card PDFs, including candidate names, DOBs and mobile numbers," Anil said on X.

Responding to the claim, IIT-Roorkee said, "Thank you @DarthKermy72747 for pointing out the configuration issue in the cloud storage device. The same is

being plugged on priority. The data stored was read-only and so there was no possibility of any alteration. We applaud your responsible and ethical behaviour."

The development comes amid a series of recent technical and operational issues reported in major national examination systems, including CUET-UG, NEET-UG and CBSE-related processes, which have faced complaints ranging from technical glitches and server-related disruptions to challenges in application, evaluation and result-processing systems.

The JEE (Advanced) is the

gateway for admission to undergraduate programmes at the Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs) and several other premier engineering institutions across the country.

The results were declared on June 1, in which 56,880 candidates were qualified in the Joint Entrance Examination (Advanced) 2026.

Of the total qualified candidates, 10,107 were female candidates, and 46,773 were male candidates.

Only one third-gender candidate appeared for the examination, but they did not qualify. The examination also saw 3,052 PwD registered candidates, of which 2,864 appeared in both papers and 887 of them qualified.

Shubham Kumar of the IIT Delhi zone secured the top rank, scoring 330 out of 360 marks.

Arohi Deshpande of the IIT Delhi zone emerged as the top-ranked female candidate with an All India Rank of 77. She scored 280 out of 360 marks.



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Free bus passes for students, formation of 10,000 Bharat Jodo Yuva Sanghas, and establishment of private employment exchange were among the youth-student-centric welfare initiatives announced by Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Wednesday, soon after taking oath.

After taking the oath of office, Shivakumar chaired the first Cabinet meeting, which decided on welfare measures, including the grant of free bus passes to all students in non-luxury Government buses. For the recruitment of youths in Government jobs, a calendar of events will be announced soon, he said.

"The Government has already announced 56,000 jobs. By the next cabinet meeting, we will call all

departments and release a calendar indicating when notifications will be issued and how the recruitment process will begin," the CM said.

Shivakumar also said that a private employment exchange will be set up where job aspirants can enrol. "Modalities for private employment exchange will be finalised within a month," he said. "For all students, whether they are in SSLC,

PUC, degree or postgraduate courses, we are giving free bus passes without charging anyone," Shivakumar told reporters after the meeting, outlining the Government's first set of policy decisions.

Shivakumar said the cabinet deliberated for more than two hours and prioritised issues concerning youth, students, employment and rural development.

The CM announced setting

up 10,000 Bharat Jodo Yuva Sangha across Karnataka to raise leadership quality and build social harmony in the State. "₹10 lakh will be given to Bharat Jodo Yuva Sangha in each of the village panchayats," he added.

The chief minister said each gram panchayat and urban ward would have one such youth body comprising 150 to 200 members, with activities centred on sports, culture, education and leadership development.

As regards modalities for private employment exchange, he said that within one month, he has asked three of his cabinet colleagues to finalise all modalities.

"We will create an online platform where industries, hospitals, hotels and other sectors can register their requirements, and youth can enrol for jobs and training," he said.

Nation Focus



PM MODI HAILS DENMARK PM ON HISTORIC THIRD TERM

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday congratulated Mette Frederiksen on assuming office as the Denmark PM for a "remarkable" third consecutive term and said he was looking forward to working closely with her to further strengthen the India-Denmark Green Strategic Partnership. In a social media post, Prime Minister Modi also said India and Denmark share an enduring partnership founded on mutual trust, shared values and a common commitment to a sustainable future. "Congratulations to my friend Mette Frederiksen on assuming office as the Prime Minister of Denmark for a remarkable third consecutive term," Modi said.

"I look forward to working closely with Prime Minister Frederiksen to further strengthen the India-Denmark Green Strategic Partnership and take our cooperation to new heights for the benefit of our peoples," he said.

(PTI)



BJP-RSS EYEING 'JAL, JANGAL, ZAMEEN' OF TRIBALS: RAHUL

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday accused the BJP-RSS of having an "anti-Adivasi mindset" and claimed that they are seeking to deprive the tribals of their rights to "jal, jangal aur zameen (water, forests, and land)". Gandhi made the remarks in a social media post after attending an event at Indira Bhawan organised by the Adivasi Congress. Gandhi addressed the gathering at the Adivasi Professionals Conclave 2026 after paying respects to Birsu Munda. He also discussed issues concerning tribals.

(PTI)

CPI(M) alleges custodial assault against Noida workers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Workers arrested during the April labourers' unrest in Noida allege they were physically assaulted in police custody, framed with fabricated evidence and booked under multiple charges to crush their movement, the CPI(M) claimed on Wednesday after a party delegation met those recently released on bail after spending nearly a month in jail.

The delegation, led by CPI(M) general secretary MA Baby, met some workers involved in the movement, many of whom have also been dismissed from their jobs following the protests.

The workers narrated their experiences to the delegation, which also included CPI(M) Polit Bureau members R Arun Kumar and Tapan Sen, Rajya Sabha member V Sivadasan and other party leaders.

The delegation also interacted with workers from



Fabstract Clothing, where around 50 employees reportedly joined the trade union movement following protests in April. Representatives of workers from Vibracoustic India also met the CPI(M) leaders and alleged that management routinely attempts to prevent workers from forming unions, while employees who assume leadership roles in such efforts are often dismissed.

Speaking after the meetings, Baby criticised the Uttar Pradesh Government for what he described as police violence against workers and the filing of false cases. He

also alleged that authorities denied permission to the delegation to visit workers who remain in jail.

"For the last few days, we have been trying to get permission through our Member of Parliament, V Sivadasan, to visit the workers in jail, but the authorities informed us that higher officials had rejected the request," Baby said.

He alleged that some jailed workers were unable to effectively pursue bail applications or secure adequate legal assistance, amounting to a denial of their fundamental rights.

India became world's second largest solar market: Bhupender

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India has emerged as the world's second-largest solar market, overtaking the United States in annual capacity additions in 2025, Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav said on Wednesday.

In a post on X, the minister stated, "This achievement reflects the nation's rapid clean energy growth, helping ensure efficient, reliable, and sustainable solar infrastructure."

While the country's solar capacity stood at 2.8 GW in 2014, it has crossed 155 GW as of today, an increase of 5,370 per cent, according to a video shared by Yadav on the social



media platform along with his post.

The video also added that India has surpassed 50 per cent non-fossil installed capacity and met its nationally determined contributions (NDC), the non-binding, voluntary climate action plans that every country is obligated to decide upon and implement under the 2015 Paris Agreement, targets ahead of schedule.

Shivakumar unveils free student bus passes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
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departments and release a calendar indicating when notifications will be issued and how the recruitment process will begin," the CM said.

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PUC, degree or postgraduate courses, we are giving free bus passes without charging anyone," Shivakumar told reporters after the meeting, outlining the Government's first set of policy decisions.

Shivakumar said the cabinet deliberated for more than two hours and prioritised issues concerning youth, students, employment and rural development.

The CM announced setting

NC to protest for J&K Statehood in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

The elected members of the Jammu Kashmir National Conference (NC) on Wednesday decided to hold a protest on the opening day of Parliament's Monsoon Session to press for the restoration of statehood to Jammu and Kashmir and seek constitutional guarantees for its people.

The decision was taken during a day-long meeting of NC legislators chaired by senior party leadership. The party resolved to intensify its political campaign for the restoration of J&K's constitutional and democratic rights.

Addressing the media after the meeting, NC Chief



Spokesperson Tanvir Sadiq

Spokesperson Tanvir Sadiq said the party would raise the issue forcefully in the national Capital, asserting that the people of Jammu and Kashmir deserve the return of their democratic and constitutional rights.

"It is time to reclaim what has been snatched from us," Sadiq said, emphasising that the restoration of statehood remains the party's foremost political priority.

States Focus



WEST BENGAL TO OBSERVE STATE DAY ON JUNE 20

The BJP Government in West Bengal will observe June 20 as State day from this year, Minister Dilip Ghosh said on Wednesday after a Cabinet meeting. He said that under Syama Prasad Mookerjee's leadership, June 20 was marked as "Bengal Day" in the then Bengal Assembly following a vote on a resolution that day in 1947, which paved the way for the partition of Bengal and the formation of the State of West Bengal. "From this year, June 20 will be officially celebrated as 'West Bengal Day,'" Ghosh said in a media briefing after a Cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari. The BJP used to mark June 20 as 'West Bengal Day' even as the previous Trinamool Congress Government used to observe it on Bengali New Year's Day, Poila Boishakh, which falls on April 14 or 15. (PTI)



TMC LEADER ARRESTED FOR ILLEGALLY OCCUPYING HOUSE

The police on Wednesday arrested Trinamool Congress spokesperson and state vice-president Jay Prakash Majumdar on the charge of harassing a woman and illegally occupying her house for several years, a police officer said. The complainant, Arati Roychowdhury, alleged that Majumdar had entered the property as a tenant around 12 years ago but subsequently stopped paying rent and continued to occupy the house. She also accused the TMC leader of refusing to vacate the premises despite repeated requests and using his political influence to remain in possession of the property, effectively driving the original owner out of her house. (PTI)

BJP accuses Mamata of insulting BR Ambedkar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Wednesday accused former West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee of "insulting" BR Ambedkar after a video purportedly showed her paying floral tributes to him while wearing footwear.

BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla shared a short video clip on social media and said, "Insulting Ambedkar has become the identity of the Trinamool Congress."

"Ambedkar ji's insult is Trinamool Congress's only identity. Trinamool Congress has insulted Ambedkar. The way in which, while paying floral tributes to Ambedkar ji, Mamata Banerjee did not even bother to remove her slippers. This shows the mindset of TMC, Mamata Banerjee and her family," he said. The BJP



leader further alleged that the TMC has repeatedly acted against the ideals and principles associated with Ambedkar. "They always insult Ambedkar ji. They have demanded Muslim reservation against Ambedkar ji's thought process. They have gone against constitutional rules. They have abused constitutional institutions like the judiciary and the Election Commission," Poonawalla

West Bengal launches Annapurna Yojana, starts ₹3,000 payout

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The West Bengal Government on Wednesday launched the Annapurna Yojana for women and began the process of transferring ₹3,000 per month to 28.25 lakh beneficiaries enrolled in the first phase.

The rollout of this financial assistance scheme was one of the key poll promises of the BJP in this year's assembly elections. It has replaced the previous TMC Government's 'Lakshmir Bhandar' scheme, under which around 2.42 crore women received a maximum of ₹1,500 per month. Inaugurating the Annapurna Yojana, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari said 28.25 lakh women had been verified and registered on the dedicated portal over the past three days.

Officials said the enrolment process will continue for the next three months, both online and offline, with applications being accepted at block development offices, municipal offices and designated Government centres. "Prime Minister Narendra Modi's guarantee and the double-engine Government's



West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari along with Cabinet Minister Agnimitra Paul launching the 'Annapurna Yojana' at Nabanna Sabhaghar in Howrah on Wednesday

commitment have ensured that the promise to provide the aid of ₹3,000 has been implemented," Adhikari said after the launch.

The chief minister said fresh applications would continue to be accepted, and all eligible beneficiaries would be brought under the scheme.

"As forms are received and verification is completed, ₹3,000 will be transferred to the beneficiaries' accounts. Our target is to ensure that every eligible woman receives the benefit," he said.

Defending the fresh registration exercise, Adhikari said the Government decided to re-verify beneficiaries after

discovering that many people whose names had been permanently deleted from electoral rolls following the Special Intensive Revision, continued to avail benefits under welfare schemes such as Lakshmir Bhandar.

He said the BJP Government was committed to ensuring that public funds reached only eligible Indian citizens and asserted that no "non-Indian" would be allowed to receive benefits under Government schemes.

The chief minister, however, clarified that persons whose cases were under appeal before tribunals and Hindu refugees from Bangladesh

who had applied for citizenship under the Citizenship Amendment Act can also apply.

Adhikari alleged that under the previous regime, ineligible beneficiaries, including men and illegal immigrants, had received benefits under women's welfare schemes, taking advantage of corruption and inadequate verification mechanisms.

"The fresh application and verification process has been introduced to ensure transparency and prevent irregularities," he said.

The chief minister also assured people that those unable to complete the enrolment process on their own would be helped by Government employees at their homes, if necessary.

The Government would issue updates every seven days on the number of verified beneficiaries and new enrolments, the chief minister said.

He said the scheme was aimed at strengthening the economic security of women and recalled the contributions of women icons from West Bengal, including Rani Rashmoni and freedom fighter Matangini Hazra.

Great Nicobar Project will cause ecological havoc: Jairam Ramesh



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Senior Congress leader Jairam Ramesh on Wednesday said the Great Nicobar Island Project, as presently conceived, is "overwhelmingly a commercial enterprise" and "ecological havoc" is assured, with the unique biodiversity of the area also being endangered.

As he shot off another letter to Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav over the Project, Ramesh said it was somewhat reassuring that democratic windows of engagement — however ritualistic — still exist and provide some hope.

In his response to Yadav's

letter of May 27 which was a reply to his earlier letter, Ramesh said his letter on May 10 was a simple plea to comply, in letter and spirit, with the law in assessing the ecological impacts of the Project in a comprehensive manner, given that the environmental impact assessment (EIA) report of March 2022 itself had stated that it is only a rapid reconnaissance study.

"I am so glad you have admitted that the environmental clearance was not based on comprehensive EIA studies based on three seasons' primary data, and primary data was collected over only a 'single seasonal cycle'," the former environment minister said.

However, the studies mentioned by you are not even based on primary data collected over a 'single seasonal cycle' as claimed. The reports themselves admit that baseline data/surveys for these reports were collected only over a few weeks. I had extracted portions of these reports for your convenience," Ramesh said.

Bihar CM directs officials to establish 11 industrial parks



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Wednesday directed officials to establish 11 mega industrial parks in the state and food parks in all 38 districts to boost industrial growth and employment generation.

He also called for the creation of a 50,000-acre land bank to accelerate industrial development and attract investment. Choudhary was speaking during a high-level review meeting of the industries department at his official residence.

According to a statement by the CMO, he said, "Industrial development is key to Bihar's prosperity and can significantly transform the State's image. The Government aims to take Bihar to new heights in industry, investment and employment generation."

The CM instructed officials to ensure adequate land availability for industrial projects.

"There is no shortage of resources in Bihar. Providing a favourable environment for investors to establish industries is the Government's highest priority," Choudhary said.

Amit Shah to chair 73rd NEC plenary session in Shillong



session on Thursday will discuss and deliberate on progress made by the CM High-level task forces constituted for critical sectors of regional development, an official statement said.

Presentations will be made on tourism, agriculture and Horticulture, investment promotion, self-reliance in milk, eggs, fish and meat, sports promotion, economic corridor development, infrastructure and connectivity, and handloom and handicrafts, the statement said.

The deliberations are expected to facilitate coordi-



Investment Summit and Bankers' Conclave, youth-focused initiatives, and efforts relating to tourism, logistics, and the Unique Selling Proposition (USP) projects in the region.

The plenary session will further deliberate on the North East Vision Plan 2047, which seeks to provide a long-term roadmap for transforming the Northeastern region into a vibrant hub of economic growth, connectivity, innovation, sustainability, and cultural prosperity by the centenary year of India's independence.

CPI(M) demands JPC probe into FCI silo contracts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Communist Party of India (Marxist) on Wednesday demanded the constitution of a Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) to enquire into the alleged corporate takeover of the country's public food security infrastructure under the guise of the Food Corporation of India's (FCI) silo modernisation scheme.

Citing a recent media exposé, the CPI(M) Polit Bureau claimed that a duopoly consisting of Adani Agri Logistics Ltd and Leap India Food & Logistics Private Ltd has secured 110 out of 134 silo contracts. The contracts, worth over ₹16,500 crore, reportedly hand over control of 46.5 lakh metric tonnes of grains out of a total projected 60 lakh metric tonnes to the two private entities.

In a press statement issued by the party's Central Committee office, the CPI(M) alleged that an initial "anti-monopoly" clause proposed by the FCI to prevent such concentration of control was deliberately removed following interventions



by the NITI Aayog and the Department of Economic Affairs to favour companies with "deep balance sheets."

"This is clearly an attempt to push the corporatisation of Indian agriculture through the back door after the defeat of the three farm laws. Even as the Government has refused to honour the promise made to the peasantry regarding the implementation of a legal guarantee of Minimum Support Price, it is undermining the strategically vital public distribution system and, as a result, India's food security," the party statement said.

Cabinet approves ₹7,597 crore highway projects in Telangana

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Union Cabinet on Wednesday approved two major National Highway widening projects in Telangana spanning a total length of 190.76 km at a cost of ₹7,597.16 crore.

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, on Wednesday approved the widening of the Armoor-Jagtial-Mancherla Section of NH-63 on the Hybrid Annuity Model (HAM) and the Jagtial-Karimnagar Section of NH-563 on the Build-Operate-Transfer to the 4-Lane standard in Telangana.

According to an official statement, the project section of Armoor-Jagtial-Mancherla passes through Nizamabad, Jagtial, and Mancherla Districts of Telangana, facing severe congestion at present due to several built-up areas along the highway, such as



Anksapoor, Korutla, Jagtial, Dharmapuri, Lakshettipet and Mancherla.

Similarly, the Jagtial-Karimnagar section passes through severely congested and heavily built-up places along the stretch, such as Jagtial, Potharam, Gangadhara and Karimnagar.

The statement said, projects are proposed to have a 4-lane configuration with bypasses to built-up areas with open tolling, ensuring design speed of 100 km/hour and improved travel efficiency across the Districts of Nizamabad, Jagtial, Mancherla and Karimnagar in Telangana. The project

will also enhance regional mobility and promote socioeconomic development, it added.

Upon completion, the statement said the travel time is expected to reduce by about one hour and 30 minutes between Armoor and Mancherla and by about 45 minutes between Jagtial and Karimnagar, while providing safe, fast, and uninterrupted connectivity for both passenger and freight traffic.

Additionally, the project will result in substantial reductions in fuel consumption, carbon emissions, and vehicle operating costs.

Maharashtra Govt's loan waiver scheme an eyewash: Sapkal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Maharashtra Congress president Harshwardhan Sapkal on Wednesday alleged that more than half of the State's farmers might be excluded from the Mahayuti Government's farm loan waiver because of the eligibility conditions, describing the scheme as an "eyewash".

A day earlier, the State Cabinet approved a ₹36,585 crore farm loan waiver scheme - 'Punyashlok Ahilyadevi Holkar Shetkari Karja-mukti Yojana' — which is expected to benefit nearly 56 lakh cultivators.

The scheme provides a loan waiver up to ₹2 lakh. The Cabinet also introduced incentive benefits for cultivators who have repaid their loans on time.

Claiming that the scheme was an "eyewash", Sapkal demanded that the Government waive the entire outstanding debt of all farmers and "clear every



farmer's 7/12 extract" by writing off their loans.

The Congress leader said the scheme would benefit only those farmers whose crop loans, disbursed between April 1, 2019 and March 31, 2025, have turned overdue.

"Farmers who had taken loans before the specified period and are unable to secure fresh crop loans due to pending dues would be left out," he alleged.

Sapkal also claimed that the number of such agriculturalists was more than double the number expected to benefit from the loan waiver

scheme and demanded that all farmers with outstanding loans be covered.

He further alleged that farmers who had availed benefits under the erstwhile MVA Government's Mahatma Jyotiba Phule Shetkari Karjamukti Yojana would now receive only a ₹50,000 incentive instead of a complete waiver of their current outstanding loans.

Sapkal said the scheme covers only crop loans and restructured loans, leaving out farmers who had borrowed for wells, pipelines, dairy animals and other agricultural investments.

Odisha Congress seeks 50% women's quota in medical, tech courses

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

The Congress on Wednesday demanded implementation of 50 per cent reservation of seats for female students in medical, engineering and other professional courses in Odisha.

Senior Congress leader Niranjan Patnaik made this demand during a press conference. The State Government on Tuesday announced enhancement of quota for SC, ST and a new quota for Socially and Economically Backward Classes (SEBC) in medical and technical education starting from the academic year 2026-27.

"We welcome the Government's decision to provide reservations to SC, ST and OBC students. Congress has been demanding this for a long time. However, why were women students left out?" Patnaik said.



Niranjan Patnaik

Since women constitute about 50 per cent of Odisha's population, the Government should provide them 50 per cent reservation in higher studies, the Congress leader demanded.

Targeting the Odisha Government and Central Government over the Mahanadi water dispute, Odisha Congress president Bhakta Charan Das said the BJP has triple-engine Governments in Odisha, Chhattisgarh and at the Centre. However, the people of Odisha have been deprived of their rights on the Mahanadi river.

Delhi Police Special Cell arrests D-Company aide Huzaifa

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Mumbai

The Delhi Police Special Cell, in coordination with the Mumbai Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS), has arrested Huzaifa. He is linked to 'D Company' and Karachi gangster Munna Jhingada. This arrest is part of a larger investigation into a Pakistan-based terror group targeting important places across India.

Huzaifa, who had been on the run, played a major role as a recruiter and organiser in the network. He followed orders from Munna Jhingada and other handlers in Pakistan, bringing in local members, handling logistics, and collecting information for possible attacks in big Indian cities.

After his arrest, authorities began checking his electronic devices for messages, financial connections, and signs of planning, widening the investigation. This arrest comes after the Special Cell recently detained eight or nine suspected terrorists, according to several sources. That opera-



tion found links between the group, Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI), and Mumbai's underworld, showing how far the network reaches.

The arrests uncovered plans to attack airports, train stations, power plants, and security forces. Police found weapons and ammunition with the suspects. Munna Jhingada, whose real name is Muddasar Hussain Sayyed, is

a shooter from Mumbai. In 2000, he went to Bangkok to attack his rival Chhota Rajan, but the attempt failed, and he spent ten years in a Thai prison.

After legal disputes about his nationality, Jhingada was sent to Pakistan in 2019. Since then, he has worked from Karachi to rebuild D-Company's network. Authorities are now working harder to find his associates

and possible sleeper cells, as they believe a team in Pakistan has used underworld connections for actions against India.

Security sources said the arrests are a major setback for the ISI and D-Company groups trying to destabilise India through hybrid warfare. "This network was not just about crime; it was about coordinated terror," a senior officer said. In short, security sources see these arrests as a serious blow to ISI and D-Company's efforts to destabilise India through hybrid warfare.

Now that Huzaifa is in custody, security agencies are stepping up their investigations into funding, recruitment, and cross-border handlers.

The Delhi Police Special Cell's ongoing investigation is likely to uncover more links, especially in Maharashtra and other areas. This highlights the ongoing threat from the ISI-underworld alliance and the continued work of Indian security forces to fight their nefarious designs.

India and Bangladesh to hold 57th BSF-BGB border talks from June 8

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Border Security Force (BSF) will host the 57th Director General-level Border Co-ordination Conference between India and Bangladesh in New Delhi from June 8 to 11 to deliberate on a wide range of strategic border management issues, according to an official statement issued on Wednesday.

The high-level bilateral dialogue, to be held at the BSF Force Headquarters in the CGO Complex, will see the Indian delegation led by BSF Director General Praveen Kumar, IPS, while the Border Guard Bangladesh (BGB) contingent will be headed by its Director General, Major General Mohammad Ashrafuzzaman Siddiqui.

A BSF spokesperson stated that the primary objective of the four-day conference is to discuss critical border-related matters and enhance real-time coordination between the two frontier-garding forces. The deliberations will extensively focus on rising security concerns, including



the prevention of assaults on BSF personnel and Indian civilians by Bangladeshi nationals, curbing trans-border crimes, and blocking the infiltration of criminals into Indian territory.

"During the course of the conference, discussions will also be held on incidents of fence breaching by Bangladeshi nationals, construction of single-row fencing, and action against Indian Insurgent Groups (IIGs) operating from inside Bangladesh," the BSF statement added.

Additionally, both sides will review progress on border infrastructure projects and explore fresh Confidence Building

Measures (CBMs) to maintain peace and tranquillity along the international boundary. The last edition of this bi-annual conference was held in Dhaka in August last year.

The institutional framework for these high-level meetings dates back to the Joint India-Bangladesh Guidelines for Border Authorities established in 1975, which mandate frequent contacts between border chiefs. Originally held annually after the first historic meeting in Kolkata in December 1975, the talks were upgraded to a bi-annual event following a Home Secretary-level agreement between the two nations in October 1993.

166 suspected Bangladeshi nationals held in Ahmedabad



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

Gujarat has stepped up its statewide campaign against illegal immigration, with police agencies conducting coordinated verification drives across major cities, including Ahmedabad, Surat, Rajkot and Vadodara. The intensified action follows directives from the State Home Department to identify and take action against individuals residing in the State without valid documentation.

The largest breakthrough has emerged from Ahmedabad, where city police carried out a special operation, codenamed "Operation Delta." According to Police Commissioner GS Malik, nearly 300 individuals were detained for verification during searches conducted in several industrial and labour-dominated localities. Following scrutiny of documents, authorities identified 166 individuals suspected of being illegal Bangladeshi nationals. The group reportedly includes men, women and children.

Meanwhile, Surat Police have launched a parallel mega drive involving the Crime Branch, Special Operations Group (SOG) and local police units. Large-scale searches and verification checks have been carried out in major industrial zones. Several individuals have been detained for verification, with officials examining identity documents, proof of residence and citizenship records. The verification process remains ongoing, and authorities are expected to release detailed findings after scrutiny is completed.

Amid the statewide operation, Gujarat Home Minister Harsh Sanghavi reaffirmed the Government's firm stance on illegal immigration.

ED summons TMC's Abhishek in primary school recruitment case



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Enforcement Directorate served a summons to Trinamool Congress MP Abhishek Banerjee on Wednesday, asking him to appear before it on June 15 in connection with the primary school recruitment irregularities case, officials said.

A team of ED officers visited Banerjee's Kalighat Road residence in south Kolkata in the evening and delivered the summons to a member of his staff as he was not present, they said.

The Diamond Harbour MP, who is the nephew of former CM Mamata Banerjee, was directed to appear before the agency at its CGO Complex office in Salt Lake, they added.

The ED has been probing the primary teacher recruitment scam since 2022. The agency has conducted multiple raids at properties linked to TMC leaders in connection with the case and arrested several heavyweights, including former

state education minister Partha Chatterjee.

Over the past year, the ED questioned several officials and attached assets worth crores of rupees, as the investigators suspect a wider conspiracy involving fraudulent appointments, tampered merit lists, and intermediaries who facilitated illegal teacher postings in state-run schools. Besides the ED, which is assessing the trail of the proceeds of crime, the CBI is investigating other aspects of the case. The two agencies have been filing charge sheets in phases as evidence is consolidated.

The ED is probing the role of Abhishek Banerjee-linked Leaps and Bounds Pvt Ltd in connection with the case after detecting suspicious transactions linked to accused middlemen, officials said. The company has been raided and its assets attached in connection with the money-laundering probe, while Banerjee has firmly denied any wrongdoing.

West Bengal Govt hands over 31 acres to BSF for border fencing

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The West Bengal Government has handed around 32 acres to the BSF for fencing along the India-Bangladesh border, a process that had been pending for several years, Panchayat Minister Dilip Ghosh said on Wednesday.

Briefing reporters after a meeting of the State Cabinet, Ghosh said the Government has also approved proposals for the transfer of land to the BSF for setting up permanent border outposts and carrying out fencing work in several border districts.

"In keeping with our first Cabinet meeting decision to hand over land to the BSF for fencing, the Government has given 31.905 acres at nine places in the State along the border with Bangladesh," Ghosh said. He said the land and land reforms depart-



Panchayat Minister Dilip Ghosh.

ment has placed before the Cabinet a proposal for the transfer of 1.53 acres in Malda, Murshidabad and Cooch Behar districts for setting up permanent border outposts at three locations along the international border.

Another proposal seeks the transfer of 12.72 acres at 11 locations in Uttar Dinajpur district to facilitate fencing work along the border, he said. The issue of land transfer for border fencing had remained contentious in the

State, with the Calcutta High Court earlier criticising the previous State Government for delays in handing over land to the BSF for securing the international border.

Ghosh said the cabinet also considered a proposal for the transfer of 20 acres of Government land at Nagrakata in Jalpaiguri district to the forest department, which would subsequently hand it over for the Sevak-Rangpo railway line project.

CM Omar chairs off-site meeting to discuss J&K statehood

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Jammu

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Wednesday 'temporarily' took a back seat in one of the air-conditioned Armani limos before embarking on a 'jungle safari' inside Dachigam National Park, where he chaired a day-long meeting with the party MLAs and MPs at Draphama Hut.

The meeting was convened by Omar Abdullah to review the functioning of his Government and to brainstorm on the future course of action needed to get the 'statehood' status restored.

Till late evening, no official statement was released by the office of the Chief Minister related to the meeting.

As per the political grapevine, the Chief Minister hosted party legislators, and

MP's away from the media glare to take their feedback and discuss the future road map. It is learnt that the host laid a sumptuous table to tease the taste buds of the invitees with the choicest 'Wazwaan' delicacies and puddings. Earlier, in a cheerful atmosphere, as the senior party leaders arrived at the Chief Minister's residence at Gupkar, they were directed to board the tempo travellers and from there they were escorted to the Dachigam National Park.

Sudden shifting of legislators from the Gupkar triggered fresh speculation, prompting the Chief Minister to clarify that the meeting was not shifted at the last moment, but it was a pre-planned move.

As per the original invitation, the Chief Minister had convened a meeting at his



residence to discuss the "matters of collective importance and public welfare".

As the party MLAs reached the venue, they were directed to board the Armani tempos to take the 22 km-long joy ride to the Dachigam National Park.

As the power corridors

were abuzz, the Chief Minister himself posted images along with a post on X, "We are off for an off-site to spend the day taking stock of the last 19 months – the good, the not so good & everything in between".

In another post, the CM said the meeting was not

shifted at the last moment, but it was a pre-planned move. "I'm sorry to disappoint you, but it has NOT 'been shifted at the last moment'. It was always my intention to conduct this meeting off-site, and all arrangements have been made, days in advance, at the location originally chosen by me," he said.

At the Dachigam National Park, as the VIPs checked in, several tourists were prevented from moving inside the park. Several social media pages and a few news outlets broadcast the interviews of stranded tourists venting their ire. Later, the Government spokesman clarified that entry to Dachigam National Park remains fully open for visitors and no restrictions have been imposed on public access today. In an official state-

ment, the Government spokesperson said the clarification was being issued in response to certain claims circulating regarding alleged restrictions on entry to Dachigam National Park on June 3, 2026.

"It is clarified that entry for all visitors to Dachigam National Park remains completely open as per the usual procedure. No restrictions have been imposed by the Government regarding entry to the park for today, June 3," the spokesperson said.

The statement further advised the public not to pay attention to unverified reports and to follow the standard protocols applicable for visits to the National Park.

"The public is advised to follow standard procedures for their visit and not to pay heed to unverified news," the spokesperson added.

Meghalaya intensifies steps to contain African Swine Fever

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Shillong

Meghalaya Government has intensified efforts to contain the spread of African Swine Fever (ASF) and imposed restrictions on pig transportation and trade in affected districts, Chief Minister Conrad K Sangma said on Wednesday.

Sangma said the outbreak was being closely monitored and immediate measures had been put in place to prevent the disease from spreading further.

"This has been a problem in the past, also. We are monitoring the situation and taking immediate action. The department is taking measures to ensure that ASF



doesn't spread on a large scale," he told reporters. According to officials, confirmed cases have been detected in Pynursla and Mawlai blocks of East Khasi Hills district, Mawthadraishan block of West Khasi Hills district, Umsning and Bhoirymbong blocks in Ri-Bhoi district, Mairang block of

Eastern West Khasi Hills district, as well as at the Regional Pig Breeding Farm in Kyrdemkulai. The affected villages include Urksew Wahpathaw, Mawkajem, Mawkynroh, Nongkasen, Kyrdemkulai, Lum Umpih, Mawkyrdap and Mawphanniew.

Ladakh to develop 10 model border hamlets

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Leh/Jammu

Ladakh Lieutenant Governor VK Saxena on Wednesday said the union territory will develop 10 model border hamlets under the vibrant village programme, with the foundation stone of the first such village laid at Chumur in eastern Ladakh.

Addressing locals during the launch of the project, Saxena described the initiative as a matter of pride and said the enthusiastic participation of villagers reflected their aspirations and wholehearted support for the ambitious programme. "The vibrant village programme, envisioned by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, aims to create self-reliant, climate-resilient, tourism-enabled



Ladakh Lieutenant Governor VK Saxena

and economically vibrant border villages in India's high-altitude frontier regions", he added.

Located at an altitude of 16,700 feet along the Indo-China border, Chumur comprises 24 households with a population of 91 people, all of whom are engaged in Pashmina rearing and production.

Saxena said under the

project, 24 modern climate-resilient houses with thermally insulated walls will be constructed for the villagers. "Each house will include an additional room suitable for homestay facilities to enhance livelihood opportunities". He added that the houses are expected to be completed by September 2026, subject to weather conditions.

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Editor's
TAKE

The OSM disaster: How students were let down

CBSE's fascination with OSM, without adequate preparedness, has left millions of students in tears

India's education establishment has a peculiar relationship with reform: it announces it loudly, implements it hastily, and then retreats into silence when things go wrong. The CBSE OSM controversy of 2026 is only the latest – and perhaps the most damaging – example of this pattern.

When CBSE introduced On-Screen Marking for Class 12 board examinations this year, it presented it as a leap into transparency and modernity. Answer scripts would be scanned, uploaded to a secure portal, and evaluated digitally by teachers from their own schools – no more physical transport, no totalling errors, no delays. The pitch was impeccable. The execution was not. What unfolded after results were declared on May 13 was, by any measure, a crisis. Students reported shockingly low marks that bore no resemblance to their preparation or performance. Many answer sheets had been scanned with blurred or illegible images, making fair evaluation almost impossible. The re-evaluation portal malfunctioned under load. Teachers, already struggling with a system they had barely trained on – in some cases for just one week – reported screen fatigue, repeated corrections, and mounting anxiety during the high-stakes evaluation period.

The rot, it turns out, ran deeper. The OSM contract was reportedly awarded to Hyderabad-based Coempt Edu Teck – the lowest bidder – over more established players. A 19-year-old cybersecurity researcher then publicly disclosed multiple critical vulnerabilities in the OSM portal, including the potential for unauthorised access to examiner accounts and modification of marks. He had reported these to CERT-In in February; most remained unpatched by May. Meanwhile, teachers in Delhi were issued show-cause notices when Class 12 results slumped at the national level – effectively penalising educators for failures that were structural.

To compound matters, CBSE had simultaneously abolished post-result verification of marks for Class 12 – the very safety net that would have allowed aggrieved students a formal recourse. The way out demands more than an apology. First, CBSE must immediately restore the right to post-result verification and process all pending re-evaluation requests free of cost, given that the fiasco was institutional rather than student-driven. Second, an independent technical audit of the entire OSM process – from scanning hubs to examiner interfaces to data security – must be commissioned and made public. Third, accountability must reach the decision-makers who overrode teacher warnings, not just the vendor. And fourth, any further expansion of OSM must follow genuine piloting, rigorous teacher training, and independent security certification. The implications for children are not abstract. Class 12 scores determine college admissions, scholarship eligibility, and in many Indian families, the entire arc of a young person's life. A wrongly awarded mark – whether too low due to a blurred scan or tampered by a security breach – is not a statistical error. It is a stolen opportunity. CBSE owes its 1.8 million Class 12 students not just answers, but justice.

DK Shivakumar: Crowning of the Kingmaker

The leadership change, following months of speculation and negotiations, reflects the Congress High Command's attempt to balance competing factions, address emerging political challenges, and prepare the party for future electoral battles



KALYANI SHANKAR

Karnataka is witnessing a significant political and generational transition with D.K. Shivakumar assuming the office of Chief Minister after the resignation of Siddaramaiah. The change comes after the Congress leadership successfully navigated a prolonged period of internal uncertainty and factional pressure. More than a routine change of guard, the transition signals a strategic recalibration by the party as it seeks to strengthen its position ahead of future electoral contests.

Shivakumar's rise is a remarkable political story. Born into a farming family, he has built a reputation as one of the Congress party's most effective organisers and crisis managers. Having won eight consecutive Assembly elections, he has emerged as a formidable political force in Karnataka. Over the years, his ability to negotiate, build alliances and manage political crises earned him the label of the Congress party's "troubleshooter."

His reputation was cemented in 2002 when the Congress-NCP government in Maharashtra faced the threat of defections. Around 40 Congress legislators were flown to Bengaluru and accommodated at a resort to shield them from poaching attempts ahead of a crucial floor test. Then Karnataka Urban Development Minister Shivakumar was entrusted with overseeing the operation. He personally coordinated the legislators' stay and ensured their safe return for the trust vote, helping the government led by Vilasrao Deshmukh survive.

Since then, Shivakumar has repeatedly demonstrated his ability to manage complex political situations. Whether safeguarding legislators, forging consensus among rival factions, or handling delicate negotiations during Rajya Sabha elections and trust votes, he has become the party's go-to strategist during moments of crisis. His extensive political network and organisational skills have often enabled the Congress to weather difficult challenges. Now, the man who helped install governments finds himself at the helm of one.

The Congress High Command's decision followed months of speculation and bargaining. Shivakumar's supporters had argued that a power-sharing understanding reached in 2023 entitled him to the chief ministership midway through the government's term. As pressure mounted, party leaders from different factions travelled to Delhi to press their case. The High Command repeatedly intervened to maintain unity and prevent



public discord before finally settling on a leadership transition.

Three major factors appear to have influenced the decision. The first was Siddaramaiah's advancing age; at 80, questions about succession had become increasingly relevant. The second was the growing challenge posed by the BJP, which has been working to regain political ground in the state. The third was the need to honour internal commitments and maintain organisational cohesion within the Congress.

Siddaramaiah leaves office with a substantial political legacy. Known for his commitment to social justice and welfare policies, he played a key role in strengthening the Congress' support among backward classes, minorities and other marginalised communities. Reflecting on his journey after stepping down, he noted that he never imagined a village boy like himself would one day become an MLA, minister and Chief Minister. His story continues to resonate with many supporters across Karnataka.

However, Siddaramaiah's continued influence may also present challenges for the new administration. His loyalists remain a significant force within the Congress legislature party and are expected to seek a meaningful role in governance. As part of the transition, discussions have reportedly centred on accommodating several of his supporters in the cabinet

and ensuring adequate representation for his political camp.

So far, the transfer of power has been remarkably smooth. Siddaramaiah himself proposed Shivakumar's name, which was seconded by senior Congress leader Parameshwara. Although the legislature party formally left the decision to the High Command, the observers eventually announced Shivakumar as the consensus choice, paving the way for his election as Congress Legislature Party leader.

Yet the real test begins now. Shivakumar must not only run the government but also manage competing interests within the party. Preventing the emergence of rival power centres while maintaining cordial relations with Siddaramaiah and his supporters will require political skill and patience. The Congress also faces the challenge of synchronising government performance with organisational strategy.

The road ahead is demanding. Karnataka Assembly elections are scheduled for 2028, followed by the Lok Sabha elections in 2029. Shivakumar's success will be measured not only by his administrative performance but also by his ability to keep the Congress united and electorally competitive. For a leader long known for solving other people's political problems, the challenge now is to govern effectively while shaping the future of both the party and the state.

SHIVAKUMAR'S SUCCESS WILL BE MEASURED NOT ONLY BY HIS ADMINISTRATIVE PERFORMANCE BUT ALSO BY HIS ABILITY TO KEEP THE CONGRESS UNITED AND ELECTORALLY COMPETITIVE

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What the death of great teaches us



RAJYOGI BRAHMA KUMAR NIKUNJ JI

2ND OPINION

The passing of celebrated personalities around the world draws millions into mourning - flowers laid at memorials, heartfelt tributes pouring in, and a collective sense of loss that transcends borders. These moments of grief reveal something profound: that certain individuals carve themselves so deeply into human hearts that their absence feels like a wound to the world itself.

Yet beyond the tears and tributes lies a deeper invitation - one that most of us decline. Each such departure is, in truth, a mirror held up to our own lives. If we were wise, we would pause and ask ourselves: Am I living meaningfully?

Am I leaving something worthwhile behind? These events carry within them the quiet whisper of a higher

order, nudging us toward self-reflection and moral awakening. Seen rightly, the death of a great soul is not merely an ending - it is a rung on a ladder, an opportunity to rise higher in our own consciousness and conduct.

Sadly, human nature in this age is deeply lethargic. The jolt of grief stirs something noble within us briefly. We feel moved to be better, kinder, more purposeful. But this feeling, like white froth on murky water, quickly fades. The noise of daily ambition and petty preoccupations returns, and we sink back into our familiar slumber, unchanged.

And yet, the lesson remains, patient and enduring. No matter one's worldview or philosophy, one truth stands undeniable: a life devoted to love, compassion, and selfless service to the suffering leaves the deepest and most lasting impression on humanity.

Wealth, power, and fame erode with time - but genuine kindness and devoted service to others etch themselves permanently into the memory of the world.

This is why millions weep for those they have never personally met. They are not mourning a body - they are mourning a spirit that elevated them.

This very observation raises a searching question. If a human being is nothing more than flesh, blood, and brain, then whom exactly do we mourn when that body lies lifeless and cold? To whom do we pray for

peace? Why do virtues like compassion, love, and selflessness feel so distinct - so often in conflict - with our purely physical impulses and desires? Does not a person sometimes willingly sacrifice their very body for a moral cause, suggesting that something within us stands apart from and above the material?

When one considers these questions honestly, alongside the vast body of accounts relating to near-death experiences, out-of-body states, and reincarnation, a compelling conclusion begins to emerge. The true actor behind the drama of life is not the body but the soul - a non-material, conscious entity that wears the body as a costume and uses it as an instrument to act, experience, and evolve. The body enables sensation; the soul gives meaning.

Embracing this truth transforms everything. Sorrow loses its stranglehold. Pettiness loses its appeal. Life gains urgent and beautiful purpose. Most importantly, this truth reminds us that our time here is not guaranteed. We must not postpone the good we intend to do, the love we mean to give, or the service we hope to render. Death teaches us, above all, to truly live - and to live well, beginning now.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a poular columnist

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Heatwaves demand urgent action

The vast difference between the officially reported figure of around 800 heat-related deaths annually and independent estimates ranging from 3,000 to 30,000 highlights a serious flaw in India's approach to recording heat mortality. By counting only deaths classified as "heatstroke," authorities overlook thousands of fatalities caused by heat-triggered cardiac arrests, kidney failures, and respiratory complications.

The issue is also one of social justice. The populations most vulnerable to extreme heat – farmers, construction workers, street vendors, and daily-wage earners – often have little choice but to continue working in dangerous conditions. Many of the states most exposed to heatwave mortality are economically weaker and lack the resources needed for effective adaptation.

Three reforms deserve immediate attention. First, heatwaves should be recognised as a notified national disaster, enabling access to emergency funds and mandatory response mechanisms. Second, mortality surveillance systems must record excess deaths associated with extreme heat rather than only heatstroke cases. Third, restrictions on outdoor work during severe heat alerts should be legally enforceable. The evidence is clear; what is needed now is decisive action.

M. BARATHI | BENGALURU

Celebrating girls' success in STEM

The announcement of JEE Advanced results is always a moment of celebration, reflecting the hard work and aspirations of thousands of students. This year's results are particularly encouraging for women in science and technology.

With 10,107 female candidates qualifying in JEE Advanced 2026, the examination recorded its highest-ever success rate for girls, with nearly one in five female candidates clearing the test. Yet, this achievement also highlights a deeper challenge. While women account for nearly half of India's STEM graduates, their representation in the workforce remains disproportionately low at around 27 per cent. Their presence in research and development is even smaller, and female faculty representation in many premier institutions continues to lag behind.

Societal attitudes and workplace barriers continue to limit opportunities for women even after they have proven their academic excellence. India must move beyond celebrating examination results and focus on creating workplaces that encourage women to remain and grow in STEM careers. Policymakers, employers, educational institutions, and society must work together to ensure that their aspirations are not hindered by outdated prejudices or structural inequalities.

SANJAY CHOPRA | MOHALI

Safeguarding integrity in the Armed Forces

The recent court-martial proceedings involving two Army officers are a matter of concern, particularly because similar cases have emerged over the past year. Although the armed forces remain among the country's most respected institutions, such incidents remind us that no organisation is entirely immune to the risk of corruption. Most military officers serve with distinction and integrity. However, assignments involving procurement, contracts, and large financial transactions can create opportunities for misconduct if adequate safeguards are not in place. Preventing corruption requires both strong systems and ethical leadership. Officers appointed to sensitive positions should be selected after careful evaluation of their integrity, reputation, and professional conduct.

Performance assessments should place greater emphasis on ethical standards alongside administrative competence. At the same time, procurement processes should become increasingly transparent and technology-driven. Digital monitoring, automation, reduced human discretion, and robust audit mechanisms can significantly limit opportunities for wrongdoing. Swift investigation and accountability are equally important to deter future misconduct.

RS NARULA | PATIALA

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE

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VIJAY MUST FOCUS ON GOVERNANCE, NOT POLITICAL POINT-SCORING

The recent "thanksgiving rally" of Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay in Tiruchi was a missed opportunity to reassure citizens about the government's priorities and future course of action. Many expected the Chief Minister, while thanking the voters of Tiruchi East who first elected him to the Assembly before he retained Perambur, to outline key policy initiatives and provide timelines for implementing manifesto promises. More importantly, the rally could have been used to address pressing issues confronting the State, particularly the growing concern over incidents of sexual violence. Citizens expected concrete measures and administrative plans to tackle such challenges. Instead, a significant portion of the 20-minute speech was devoted to

political rhetoric, personal rebuttals, criticism of opponents, and responses to comments about his attire. The event appeared more like a party campaign gathering than a platform for governance. Political exchanges may energize supporters, but they do little to inform the public about the government's roadmap. Leadership demands a focus on policy, institution-building, and accountability rather than personal confrontations. Tamil Nadu deserves a clear vision backed by action plans and measurable outcomes. As CM, Mr. Vijay must rise above partisan politics and demonstrate the maturity, restraint, and administrative focus expected from the holder of the State's highest elected office.

RANGANATHAN SIVAKUMAR | CHENNAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

The menace of illegal infiltration: A threat India can no longer ignore

The problem of illegal infiltration is multi-dimensional – economic, social, political, and administrative – demanding a comprehensive, coordinated national response



ASHWANI MAHAJAN

The Election Commission of India (ECI) recently undertook a significant initiative called the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) to clean up electoral rolls across the country. The exercise aimed at correcting longstanding deficiencies - including the wrongful inclusion of foreign nationals, failure to remove deceased voters' names, duplicate entries, and discrepancies caused by frequent migration. Where foreign nationals appeared on the rolls, their names were automatically deleted, as they were unable to furnish proof of citizenship. After resolving objections, a cumulative total of 52 million voters were removed from electoral rolls across 12 states and 3 Union Territories.

Despite facing strong opposition from several political parties, the SIR process received the Supreme Court's stamp of constitutional validity, effectively silencing critics. While this cleansing of voter rolls marks a commendable step forward, it represents only one piece of a far larger puzzle. The more pressing and complex challenge - that of physically identifying and expelling illegal foreign infiltrators from Indian soil - remains very much unresolved.

For decades, illegal Bangladeshi infiltration has been steadily escalating across various parts of India. This is not a new or isolated problem; it is a deeply entrenched crisis that has, unfortunately, been repeatedly politicized rather than addressed with the urgency it demands. It is worth noting that developed nations - including the United States and several European countries - are enacting increasingly stringent laws against illegal immigration and pursuing enforcement with firm resolve. India deserves no less. Recently, Union Home Minister Amit Shah constituted a high-level committee to address the issue of illegal infiltration and the resulting demographic changes.

The move comes against the backdrop of the alarming scale of Bangladeshi infiltration in West Bengal - a state that shares a long and porous border with Bangladesh. For years, critics alleged that the previous state government under former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee extended tacit patronage to illegal infiltrators.

With the BJP now in power in West Bengal, there are clear signals that the government is prepared to adopt a firm, uncompromising stance on this issue.

Numbers That Tell a Disturbing Story

While no definitive official figure exists, the numbers cited over the years are staggering. In 2004, the UPA government stated in Parliament that approximately 12 million Bangladeshis were residing illegally in India - though the government later hastily distanced itself from this figure, dismissing it as based on hearsay.

By 2016, Minister Kiren Rijiju of the NDA government placed the number at 20 million - a figure 70 percent higher than the UPA's own estimate from just twelve years prior. By 2017, the government acknowledged that obtaining precise data on the number of infiltrators was virtually impossible.

Regardless of the exact figures, the trajectory is unmistakably alarming. Opposition parties have occasionally acknowledged the severity of the problem even while in power, but have made no meaningful efforts toward a lasting solution.

Rather than evaluating this issue through the narrow prism of electoral politics, it must be approached from the perspective of national interest and long-term social stability.

The economic fallout of illegal infiltration is both direct and devastating. India already faces the enormous challenge of generating sufficient employment for its vast and young population. When illegal Bangladeshi workers willingly accept wages far below market rates, Indian laborers - especially from vulnerable communities - are effectively pushed out of the workforce. This displacement is visible across both the domestic sector and industrial employment.

A significant share of India's economy operates through the unorganized sector - comprising small shopkeepers, street vendors, hawkers, scrap collectors,



construction laborers, and market workers. In virtually all these spheres, Bangladeshi infiltrators are increasingly cornering economic opportunities, often through well-organized syndicates.

This directly undermines the livelihoods of Indian citizens who depend on these very sectors for their survival. Since these infiltrators operate almost entirely within the informal economy, the government collects no tax revenue from their economic activities.

Worse still, earnings made in India are illegally remitted back to Bangladesh, bleeding the Indian economy further. Adding insult to injury, many infiltrators exploit welfare schemes meant exclusively for India's poor - obtaining free rations, subsidized electricity, water connections, and even bank accounts - using fraudulent documents. This misuse results in a loss of crores to the national exchequer every year.

The pressure on public services in infiltration-prone areas is mounting at an alarming pace. Healthcare facilities, schools, sanitation systems, and subsidised food distribution networks in affected regions are strained beyond capacity. Illegal procurement of Aadhaar cards, ration cards, and voter identity cards has created a governance nightmare.

Distinguishing between genuine citizens and illegal infiltrators becomes increasingly difficult when fraudulent documentation is widespread, thereby compromising internal security and administrative integrity. Demographic shifts triggered by large-scale infiltration also generate serious social tensions. Border districts in particular witness cultural and linguistic imbalances as migrant populations grow disproportionately.

Competition over land, employment, and welfare resources routinely sparks conflicts between local communities and migrant groups. Crime rates - including human trafficking, organized criminal activity, and illegal land encroachment - tend to be significantly higher in areas with heavy infiltration. The political consequences are equally troubling. Illegal infiltrators have, on numerous occasions, influenced election outcomes by being fraudulently registered as voters - directly undermining the integrity of Indian democracy.

The appeasement of minority vote banks by certain parties has only deepened this problem, eroding sound political values and rewarding illegal presence over legitimate citizenship. The problem of illegal infiltration is multi-dimensional - economic, social, political, and administrative - and demands a comprehensive, coordinated national response.

The government's current initiatives, if pursued with consistency and resolve, hold the potential to significantly reduce the crisis threatening India's socio-economic and democratic fabric. The time for half-measures and political hedging has long passed. What India needs today is political will, administrative efficiency, and national unity in confronting this challenge head-on.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

DISTINGUISHING BETWEEN GENUINE CITIZENS AND ILLEGAL INFILTRATORS BECOMES INCREASINGLY DIFFICULT WHEN FRAUDULENT DOCUMENTATION IS WIDESPREAD, THEREBY COMPROMISING INTERNAL SECURITY AND ADMINISTRATIVE INTEGRITY

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 The Pioneer

Clean tech, dirty habits: India's sustainability paradox



SHWETA THAKUR NANDA

In a world overflowing with viewpoints, conservation discussions often gravitate towards renewable energy, green hydrogen, smart cities, electric vehicles, battery storage, and carbon markets. These technological breakthroughs and innovations are presented as solutions that will shape our environmental future.

They deserve the spotlight. However, what often gets overlooked is that we cannot consume our way out of climate change. The real challenge is behavioural.

Ecological deterioration and climate change are often debated as problems created by industries, governments, and macro-level financial systems. That is true, but only partially. We cannot ignore how environmental degradation is also the cumulative result of our everyday choices and practices that we, as a society and as communities, have normalised over time.

For instance, disposable plastic continues to be viewed through the prism of convenience rather than as a harmful pollutant. Indians are increasingly using personal vehicles for travelling short distances - even to a salon or a gym. We leave public places dirty while keeping our homes spotless. We compulsively buy fast fashion despite knowing its environmental toll. These seemingly harmless individual choices collectively form a large ecological footprint.

Consider this data point: globally, 92 million tonnes of textile waste is generated every year, according to the UNEP. And India is one of the largest textile and apparel markets in the world, and the third largest exporter in this sector.

The challenge is not only to build sustainable infrastructure in a country like India, but also to build planet-positive habits. Clean technology and dirty habits will not give us a sustainable future.

But there is a silver lining. India has demonstrated in the past that behaviour change is possible at scale. The eradication of polio required convincing millions of families to embrace vaccination. The adoption of LPG connections under clean cooking initiatives required changes in household behaviour. The change in sanitation practices was achieved by shifting cleanliness from a private chore to a collective civic



duty. Alongside social change, India has also achieved financial revolutions through behaviour change. Consider how UPI and QR codes have transformed our financial transactions. In May 2026, 23.2 billion UPI transactions were carried out in India - a 24% year-on-year growth, according to data from the National Payments Corporation of India. As per NPCI, Indians carry out an average of 748 million daily transactions worth 796,465 crore. From humble vegetable vendors to luxury showrooms, from essential medicine stores to places of worship, our digital payment system has metamorphosed from a niche practice into a mainstream habit.

These examples underline that meaningful change happened not only because policies existed, but because of behaviour change. Essentially, people seldom change behaviour out of fear or risk. It happens when the alternative behaviour makes their life easier, socially desirable, culturally accepted, and at times economically rewarding.

Environmental action requires a similar shift. Where environmental campaigns fall short is that the majority of messaging around ecological conservation is hinged on guilt, fear, or risk. People are constantly cautioned that climate change is an existential threat and that pollution is catastrophic. None of it is untrue. Yet fear, threat, or guilt rarely bring about the desired behaviour change. People gradually become indifferent.

Can carrying a steel water bottle be seen as modern rather than frugal? Can waste segregation become as socially expected as wearing a seatbelt while driving? Can carrying cloth bags to buy groceries be celebrated rather than invite raised eyebrows from neighbours? Can reusing clothes or taking public transport indicate civic maturity rather than economic limitation? Can we conserve water not as a sacrifice, but as responsible citizenship?

Social norms matter because human beings are deeply influenced by what they observe around them - they connect with and mirror their peers. Is it not the same principle on which the creator economy is flourishing?

So, when planet-positive behaviour becomes more visible and admired, and its adoption is celebrated, change will happen faster.

India's upwardly mobile middle class will play a crucial role in this transition. Rising income is changing consumption patterns. The question now is whether a resource-intensive lifestyle or planet-positive choices will be seen as symbols of growth, status, and societal maturity. Slight nudges often accomplish results that regulations alone cannot. That is why public policy should consciously adopt behavioural insights.

The real transition will not happen in laboratories, industries, or boardrooms alone - it will happen in kitchens curbing food waste, in offices reducing consumption, in gated communities managing waste responsibly, and in people choosing how they shop, travel, and use resources.

Technology will remain vital in mitigating ecological challenges. But technology alone cannot build climate resilience - it equally depends on changing our habits: the way we live, consume, and care.

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 The Pioneer

Cervical cancer prevention: Why linking HPV awareness matters



CHARU PRAGYA

On the Menstrual Hygiene Day (May 28), Delhi CM Rekha Gupta raised a very powerful voice by promising No more silence on Menstruation. While many political leaders and public figures treat menstrual hygiene as a welfare issue and focus on just the distribution of sanitary pads, she is trying to institutionalise the apparatus and position menstrual health as a public health matter.

In her article, the Delhi CM also linked menstrual hygiene to cervical cancer awareness. "This (menstrual hygiene) will be directly linked to awareness of HPV and cervical cancer. Cervical cancer remains one of the most common cancers among Indian women, and it is also one of the most preventable. By connecting menstrual health to HPV awareness, we treat a girl's reproductive health holistically," she argued.

India needs to treat health as a continuous journey instead of just focusing on building cure infrastructure. While all the new hospitals, the increase in the number of medical seats, colleges, and Jan Aushadhi Kendras are essential to ensure that no one loses lifespan or healthspan due to unfortunate incidents, the

focus should be on minimising the need for the same in the first place.

A good parallel would be the city transport infrastructure - the European cities initially focused on improving the road and metro infrastructure for city commute, but could never keep up with the growing population and its needs - later they realised that the solution lies in eliminating/minimising vehicle commute altogether and redesigned the city for pedestrian and cycle traffic. And the result of this is that European cities are cleaner, the population is healthier, and the quality of life is much better. Similarly, we need to minimise the need for healthcare infrastructure by focusing on preventive healthcare.

According to the WHO, cervical cancer is the 2nd most common cancer after breast cancer among women in India. Cervical Cancer is primarily driven by Human Papillomavirus (HPV), and our country accounts for roughly 20% of the global cervical cancer burden against 18% of the global population. Cervical cancer is preventable through vaccination administered between the ages of 9 and 14 before any exposure to the virus.

Adolescence represents a narrow, vital developmental window. Treating menstruation, reproductive education, and cancer prevention as completely separate may make sense from a curative point of view, but from a preventive lens, all of this could be dealt with a holistic strategy. When a young girl learns



about her reproductive system in early teens, this is the right time to introduce her to the preventive vaccination framework, also.

Many authoritative studies have pointed out that schools are the basis for preventive healthcare interventions. Sensitisation about HPV and the vaccination to prevent the same will end the pandemic and will make our coming generations healthy and productive.

For too long, India has focused on curative

healthcare despite being a low-per-capita-income country. While we see the 'prevention is better than cure' slogan in almost every other clinic and hospital, preventive healthcare has not been the focus of the community or the policymakers. India has one of the highest out-of-pocket healthcare expenditures (OOPHE) in the world at 43%. It was even higher, 64 per cent a decade ago, but thanks to the Modi government's focus on healthcare infrastructure and

improved spending, the ratio has decreased significantly. However, in a lower-middle-income country, people cannot afford to pay 43% OOPHE, which means the majority of India's population is one medical bill away from being pushed below the poverty line.

The people of the United States, with a per capita income of around 90,000 dollars (30 times that of India), can afford to pay OOPHE, and most of Europe has fully public healthcare, but given India's stage of development, both of these models are unsustainable for us. Thus, we have to focus on preventive healthcare in a big way if we want to have a healthy country that can reap the benefits of the demographic dividend by participating in the economy. Various studies have shown that health is directly linked to productivity, and as the cases of obesity, diabetes, breast and cervical cancer increase, the productivity of our young population will go down. If this demographic window is lost, India risks becoming old before becoming rich, and unless the country focuses on preventive healthcare to improve the healthspan and lifespan of the population, this risk will linger on. Therefore, our political leaders and public figures need to work on this on a war footing.

Charu Pragya is the founder and panelist, BJP

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**SC form expert panel to
re-examine Aravalli definition**

The Supreme Court has constituted a high-powered committee to conduct an independent review of the Centre's report on the definition and delineation of the Aravalli hill range and directed the panel to address what it described as "critical ambiguities" in the findings. The committee headed by Kanchan Devi, Director General of the Indian Council of Forestry Research and Education (ICFRE) has been directed to submit a comprehensive report by August 31, 2026. The move comes months after the apex court, on December 29, stayed the implementation of an October 2025 report prepared by a committee chaired by the Secretary of the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC). The court had then emphasised the need for an independent body of domain experts to undertake a fresh scientific and ecological assessment. In its order, the court observed that a "fair, impartial and independent expert opinion" was necessary after consulting all relevant stakeholders to provide definitive guidance on several contentious. The newly constituted high-powered committee (HPC) will be chaired ex-officio by Kanchan Devi, a 1991-batch Indian Forest Service officer. The committee's members include Dr SubhasH Ashutosh, former Director General of the Forest Survey of India; Dr Rajendra Kumar Sharma, former Director of the Geological Survey of India; Brij Mohan Singh Rathore, former Joint Secretary in the Environment Ministry; and Prof Ashok K Bhatnagar, former Head of the Department of Botany at Delhi University.

(PTI)

Delhi HC permits 50-year-old woman to claim embryos

The Delhi High Court has permitted a woman aged 50 years and two months to receive her cryopreserved embryos even after crossing the threshold age, saying reproductive rights and access to parenthood cannot be reduced to purely technical or pedantic application of statutory conditions. Justice Purushaindra Kumar Kaurav said the embryos were retrieved at a point when the woman was undisputedly within prescribed age bracket and the object of the Assisted Reproductive Technology Regulation (ART) Act was not to create "insurmountable barriers" in the continuation of lawfully undertaken treatment processes. The ART Act stipulates that a woman has to be above the age of 21 and below the age of 50, and a man has to be above the age of 21 years and below the age of 55 years. While dealing with the petition by the woman and her husband, the court stated that reproductive rights .

(PTI)



Citizens view law enforcers with suspicion when they extort: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

When law enforcers turn extortionists, the citizen looks with suspicion and is left in a dilemma, the Supreme Court has said while cancelling the anticipatory bail granted to three police officers accused of alleged extortion.

A bench comprising justices Sanjay Kumar and K Vinod Chandran set aside the order passed by the Bombay High Court while terming it 'cryptic'. "When law enforcers turn extortionists, the citizen looks askance and is left in a dilemma. To confront, is to invite instant retaliation and the option is only to succumb meekly to the uniformed authority, even when there is patent abuse," the bench said.

In this case, the complainant was travelling with his daughter from Mumbai in the Hapa Duronto Express. They, along with his brother-in-law who came to see him off, were detained by police personnel of the sabotage-detection detail at the



railway station. While searching the passenger's baggage, a gold bar of 14 grams and cash of ₹31,900 were detected.

Despite giving a satisfactory explanation, one of the uniformed men took the three to a nearby room wherein they were intimidated and verbally abused, it was alleged. They were

forced to give the cash in return for the gold bar. The complainant lodged an FIR following which the officers were denied anticipatory bail by the sessions court.

The high court in the instant case granted anticipatory bail to the three officers after viewing the CCTV footage collected in the course of investigation,

finding the accused to be wearing identity cards.

It also noted that the complainant and his daughter showed no signs of distress, coupled with the delay in lodging the FIR and unblemished service of the accused.

The top court said that while the expressions of the persons are not clear in the CCTV footage, there are some clear signs of distress which the high court surprisingly failed to notice.

"We are surprised that the High Court observed that there is no sign of distress on them, especially when their expressions are not clear in the footage. We also noticed that the two adults were moving ahead, one of them gesturing frantically with his hands while the child was trailing behind, a definite indication of distress.

"We also find that the time they spent inside the closed room was sufficient for the police men to carry out the complained of actions, which we hasten to observe have to be in any event proved in a criminal trial," the bench said.

Coal block case: Delhi court summons Naveen Jindal, former secretary

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has summoned industrialist and Lok Sabha MP Naveen Jindal, former coal secretary PC Parekh and others after taking cognisance of a CBI chargesheet alleging irregularities in the allocation of Gare Palma IV/I coal block in Chhattisgarh.

"The instant chargesheet, which is stated to be one of the most voluminous chargesheets of coal block cases, has been filed by CBI after more than a decade of registration of the FIR," Special Judge Sunena Sharma said, adding that there is sufficient material for the court to proceed in the matter.

The court summoned on July 17 M/s Jindal Steel and Power Ltd, its managing director Naveen Jindal, Parekh, Rakesh Kumar Jindal, Ram Kishore, SK Agarwal and M/s Jindal Strips Ltd (now M/s Nalwa Sons Investments Ltd). The case stems from a preliminary inquiry registered by the CBI based on directions from the Central



Vigilance Commission (CVC) on September 26, 2012.

The judge said that the chargesheet contains 778 documents running into more than 1 lakh pages and 234 listed witnesses.

Besides the lengthy investigation involving voluminous records and numerous witnesses, the time taken by the competent authorities in according the requisite prosecution sanction in respect of the accused public servants is cited as one of the major reasons for the inordinate delay in filing the chargesheet, the judge noted in the order on cognisance dated June 1.

Court frames charges against Jacqueline, Sukesh Chandrashekar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Setting the stage for trial, a Delhi court on Wednesday formally framed charges against actor Jacqueline Fernandez, alleged conman Sukesh Chandrashekar and 15 others in a ₹200-crore money laundering case.

In a separate case registered by the Delhi Police's Special Cell, the court also framed charges against Chandrashekar and 20 others for various offences, including under the stringent MCOCA provisions.

Chandrashekar, Jacqueline, and several others appeared in person in the court on Wednesday afternoon. Pleading not guilty to the charges, the accused persons claimed trial before Additional Sessions Judge (ASJ) Prashant Sharma.

On May 30, in two separate orders, the court had ordered framing charges in the two cases, saying prima facie, there is sufficient material against the accused.

In the ED case, ASJ Sharma had said that the accused persons "have to be charged with the offence (of money laundering) under Section 3 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), punishable under Section 4 of the PMLA.

In the case registered by the special cell and later probed by the



Actor Jacqueline Fernandez arriving at Patiala House Court in New Delhi

PTI

economic offences wing, the judge had ordered framing of charges against Chandrashekar for personating a public servant, extortion, cheating, criminal intimidation, criminal conspiracy, along with IT Act provisions and MCOCA sections for committing an organised crime and possessing unaccountable wealth on behalf of members of an organised crime syndicate.

He had also ordered framing of similar charges, except for the offence of impersonating a public servant, against Chandrashekar's wife, Leena Paulose.

The judge had said that charges be

framed against 17 others for various penal offences, and under the IT Act and MCOCA provisions for committing organised crime.

MCOCA, or the Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act, 1999, is a law enacted to combat organised crime syndicates and terrorism. The Act equips authorities with special powers to track, intercept, and penalise gang-related criminal activities that normal penal codes fail to deter.

Three others were also ordered to be charged with offences of criminal conspiracy and cheating. Jacqueline, whom the

Enforcement Directorate (ED) summoned several times in connection with the probe, was named as an accused for the first time in a supplementary chargesheet filed by the agency.

The ED alleged in its second supplementary complaint against Jacqueline that she was in constant touch with Chandrashekar and had received valuable gifts from him through Pinky Irani.

According to the prosecution, Chandrashekar was running an organised criminal network from inside jail and was impersonating senior government officials, including those from the Prime Minister's Office (PMO), the Ministry of Home Affairs, and the Ministry of Law and Justice.

It claimed that by using spoofed calls, encrypted applications and fabricated identities, the accused induced complainant Aditi Singh and her family members to part with huge sums of money.

The ED alleged that Chandrashekar generated proceeds of crime amounting to more than ₹200 crore through extortion, cheating, impersonation and criminal intimidation, and thereafter concealed, possessed, transferred, layered and projected the same as untainted property with the help of his associates.

SC collegium clears three judges for Himachal HC



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court collegium has approved a proposal for appointment of three judicial officers as judges of the Himachal Pradesh High Court.

The collegium, headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, in a meeting held on June 2 approved names of Chirag Bhanu Singh, Bhupesh Sharma, and Yogesh Jaswal as judges of the Himachal Pradesh High Court.

The collegium also approved the proposal for appointment of additional judges — Justice Harmeet Singh Grewal and Justice Deepinder Singh Nalwa — as permanent judges of the Punjab and Haryana High Court.

It approved the proposal for appointment of six advocates — Raghavendra Seetharam Srivatsa, Hema Kulkarni, Subramanya Rangarao, Thadagavadi Prakash Vivekananda, Bakkeswara Pramod and Hombe Gowda Shanthi Bhushan — as judges of the Karnataka High Court.

Another statement said the collegium has approved the proposal for appointment of advocate Amit Lahoti as a judge of the Madhya Pradesh High Court.

Petition in Allahabad HC against UP Assembly principal secretary's appointment, tenure

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

A petition has been filed in the Allahabad High Court against the appointment of Uttar Pradesh Assembly Principal Secretary Pradeep Kumar Dubey and his continuation in the office beyond the prescribed retirement age. The matter came up before Justice Jaspreet Singh, who recused himself from hearing the case, and directed that it be placed before another bench.

The Lucknow bench of the court ordered that the petition be listed after fresh nomination by the Chief Justice or the concerned senior judge.



The petition was filed by Karmesh Pratap Singh, a former Information Officer to the Speaker of the Uttar Pradesh Legislative Assembly.

The petitioner has questioned the legal authority with which Dubey continues to hold the office of Principal Secretary. The plea alleges

that Dubey's appointment in 2009 violated the Uttar Pradesh Legislative Assembly Secretariat (Recruitment and Conditions of Service) Rules, 1974, which prescribed an upper age limit of 52 years for appointment to select-category posts. According to the petition, Dubey had already

crossed the age limit when he was appointed.

The petitioner has sought the court's directions requiring Dubey to establish the legal authority under which he continues to hold the post, and has also requested an interim order restraining him from exercising the powers of the office pending adjudication of the case.

The plea States that Dubey took voluntary retirement from the Uttar Pradesh Judicial Service on January 13, 2009, and was appointed Principal Secretary (Parliamentary Affairs) on the same day.

Prolonged matrimonial litigation only leads to perpetuity of marriage on paper: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prolonged pendency of matrimonial litigation only leads to perpetuity of marriage on paper, the Supreme Court has said while dissolving the marriage between an estranged couple who were living separately for more than 15 years.

The apex court noted that the Rajasthan High Court had granted divorce in favour of the husband on many grounds, including cruelty committed by the wife against him by denying sexual relations on several occasions.

"The courts in India have repeatedly established that withholding sexual intimacy inflicts severe emotional distress and undermines the

bedrock of marriage," a bench of Justices Sanjay Karol and Augustine George Masih said. "Therefore, the conclusion of the high court is sustained. The decree of divorce as granted by allowing the appeal of the respondent-husband is upheld," it said.

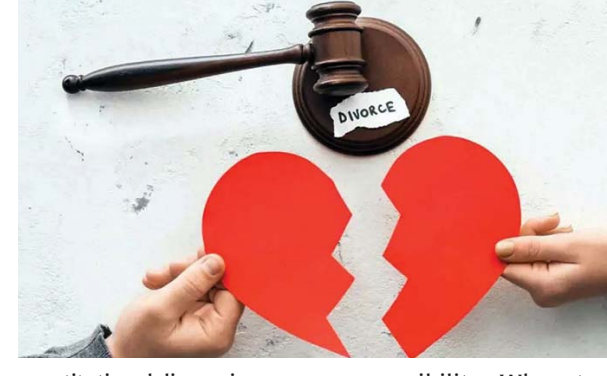
It noted that as held in several judgments of the top court, denial of conjugal rights including persistent refusal of sexual intercourse without a reasonable cause constitutes mental cruelty and is a valid ground for divorce under Section 13(1)(ia) of the Hindu Marriage Act.

The bench noted that both the wife and the husband, who were married in December 2007, are doctors and are in government service in Gujarat and Rajasthan, respectively.

Exercising its powers under Article 142 of the Constitution to do complete justice, the top court said the marriage between the couple deserves to be dissolved as it was apparent that the wedlock has broken down irretrievably. The top court delivered its judgement on June 2 on an appeal filed by the wife challenging a February last year order of the high court.

The high court had allowed the appeal filed by the husband and granted him divorce.

In its verdict, the apex court noted that the parties were living separately for over 15 years, there was no child from the wedlock and despite repeated efforts by the courts, there was no reconciliation. The bench said marriage, in its legal and



constitutional dimension, can never be reduced to a mere contractual intersection of individual rights, nor can it be viewed strictly through the narrow lens of a petition for conjugal rights.

"It is a deeply personal and social partnership built on mutual respect, shared expectations and equal

responsibility. When two parties enter into matrimony, they weave a tapestry of interdependence that demands a continuous balancing of interests," it said. The bench said conjugal rights do not exist in a vacuum and that they are the structural counterparts to conjugal duties.

"To demand the fulfilment of the former while willfully abandoning the sanctity of the latter is to undermine the very essence of the institution," the bench said.

It said persistent withdrawal from the foundational aspects of marriage may have legal consequences while evaluating allegations of mental cruelty.

The bench said from the conduct of parties in this case, it was clear that even during the short period of cohabitation, they failed to perform their conjugal responsibilities.

"This court is conscious of the view that approach of the courts should be to preserve the sanctity of marriage and the court should be reluctant to dissolve the marriage at the mere asking of one of the

parties," it said.

The bench said in this case, the parties had lived separately for far too long a period of time and there was no sanctity left in the marriage.

Although it was claimed by the wife, it said, that she had left her job in Gujarat and started living in Rajasthan, no evidence has come on record to substantiate the claim.

"Rather the evidence on record is to the contrary and it is not disputed that she still continues with her job in Gujarat.

There appears to be no intention on her part to join company of the husband as actions speak more than the dry words," the bench said.

It added, "This court is also of the view that prolonged pendency of matrimonial litigation only leads to perpetu-

ity of marriage on paper." The bench said it was in the best interest of parties and the society if ties were severed between parties in cases where litigation was pending for a considerably long period of time.

"Prolongation of a matrimonial relationship would further lead not only to escalation of frustration in a dead relationship, which has already decayed and is decomposing day by day creating foul sociological, psychological and mental hollowness in life resulting in denial of a free and independent environment to flourish which each human strives in body and soul," it said.

The bench, while dismissing the appeal filed by the wife, dissolved the marriage between the couple.

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Wheat procurement rises to 35 MT, exceeds target for 2026-27

The Government’s wheat procurement rose 17 per cent to over 35 million tonne (MT) in the 2026-27 rabi marketing season, surpassing both the target of 34.5 MT and the previous year’s procurement of 30 MT, a senior food ministry official said on Wednesday.

“Wheat procurement has crossed 35 million tonne so far this season. We have exceeded the target. Procurement in major producing states has been completed,” the official said.

The Food Corporation of India (FCI) and state agencies procure wheat at the minimum support price (MSP) to meet requirements under the National Food Security Act and other welfare schemes.

Higher procurement was facilitated by mandi rates ruling below the MSP, owing to robust domestic production of 120.65 MT, sustained despite localised crop damage from unseasonal rainfall and hailstorms.

State-wise, Punjab led procurement at 12.1 MT, up from 11.9 MT in the previous season. Madhya Pradesh recorded a sharp jump to 10.4 MT from 7.8 MT, while Haryana rose to 8.1 MT from 7 MT.

Uttar Pradesh nearly doubled its procurement to 1.7 MT from 1 MT, and Rajasthan improved to 2.4 MT from 1.9 MT.

Wheat procurement season runs from April through March. However, much of the procurement happens in the first few months itself. (PTI)

Rupee falls 31 paise, closes at 95.67 against US dollar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ MUMBAI

The rupee depreciated 31 paise to close at 95.67 (provisional) against the US dollar on Wednesday, after the US Trade Representative proposed a 12.5 per cent additional duties on Indian imports, citing labour violations. Forex traders said strong dollar demand, surging crude oil prices, geopolitical tensions, and relentless foreign capital outflows dented investor sentiment further.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.43 against the US dollar, then touched an intraday low of 95.80 and finally ended the session at 95.67 (provisional), down 31 paise from its previous close.

On Tuesday, the rupee depreciated 17 paise to close at 95.36 against the US dollar. Forex traders said the US Trade Representative’s action, amid fresh hostilities and stalled talks between the US and Iran, weighed on investor sentiment.

The US Trade Representative has proposed 12.5 per cent additional duties on 54 countries, including India, for failing to prohibit the import of goods produced with forced labour.

Meanwhile, the government said India is engaged with the US on the Section 301 investigations over concerns related to forced labour and excess

Date	Rate (₹ per US \$)	Change
May 26	95.58	+12p
May 27	95.70	+44p
May 29	94.85	+73p*
May 31	95.19	-34p
June 1	95.36	-17p
June 3	95.67*	-31p

*Provisional
Source: KBK Infographics

industrial capacity. The country is also “parallelly” engaged with the US for finalisation of an interim trade agreement, a framework for which was announced through a joint statement on February 7.

The Office of the United States Trade Representative (USTR) launched two separate Section 301 investigations on March 11 and 12, 2026, covering 60 economies over concerns related to forced labour and excess industrial capacity. Meanwhile, market participants are now turning their attention to the RBI MPC rate decision on June 5, as inflation, growth and the rupee are under focus.

The RBI Monetary Policy Committee meeting is scheduled for June 3-5. The six-member MPC, headed by RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra, will announce decision on June 5.

fied overnight,” brokerage firm Kotak Neo said.

The US and Iran have exchanged fire, with Iran launching missiles toward Kuwait and Bahrain, which

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BUSINESS

11

US proposes 12.5% tariffs on India over forced labour

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington/New Delhi

The US has proposed to impose 12.5 per cent tariffs on 54 countries, including India, for allegedly failing to prohibit the import of goods produced with forced labour, even as officials from New Delhi and Washington are currently holding three-day talks to finalise the first tranche of the bilateral trade agreement. The talks that started on Tuesday are being held in New Delhi.

Reacting to the proposed 12.5 per cent tariff, the Indian commerce ministry said New Delhi is engaged with the US on the two Section 301 investigations — over concerns related to forced labour and excess industrial capacity. The country is also “parallelly” engaged with the US for finalisation of an interim trade agreement, a framework for which was announced through a joint statement on February 7.

The US Trade Representative (USTR) has proposed the additional duty following investigations launched in March against 60 countries under Section 301 of the Trade Act of 1974 over concerns related to forced labour.

The measure remains a proposal and has not yet been finalised, the USTR said, adding that interested parties can submit requests to appear at hearings and summaries of testimony by June 22. The USTR is scheduled to hold hearings on July 7.

“India remains engaged with the US on the matter as a part of Section 301 proceedings. India is also parallelly engaged with the US for finalisation of a framework agreement as was announced on 2nd February 2026 and in accordance with the joint statement released on 7th February 2026,” the commerce ministry said.

The USTR has proposed

U.S. PROPOSES ADDITIONAL TARIFFS OVER FORCED LABOUR IMPORT RULES
ENSURING FAIR TRADE. PROTECTING HUMAN RIGHTS. SUPPORTING AMERICAN WORKERS.

The U.S. Trade Representative (USTR) has proposed additional duties on countries that fail to prohibit and effectively enforce bans on goods produced with forced labour.

COUNTRIES IMPACTED BY THE PROPOSED U.S. ACTION

- 12.5% ADDITIONAL DUTY (Proposed)**
Economies that do not impose and effectively enforce a prohibition: CHINA 12.5%, JAPAN 12.5%, INDIA 12.5%, SAUDI ARABIA 12.5%, AUSTRALIA 12.5%, BRAZIL 12.5%, UNITED KINGDOM 12.5%.
- 10% ADDITIONAL DUTY (Proposed)**
Economies that have partial measures, commitments, or have not effectively enforced existing prohibitions: OTHER COUNTRIES.

12.5% ADDITIONAL DUTY – 54 COUNTRIES
Include (but not limited to): India, China, South Africa, UAE, Chile, Bangladesh, Egypt, Peru, Vietnam, Sri Lanka, Argentina, Philippines, Cambodia, Mexico, Thailand, Singapore, Indonesia, And 30+ other countries, Saudi Arabia, Turkey, Pakistan.

10% ADDITIONAL DUTY (Proposed)
Have partial measures, commitments or not effectively enforced existing prohibitions: Canada, Ecuador, European Union, Mexico, Pakistan.

OTHER COUNTRIES
Not subject to proposed additional duties at this stage.

INDIA: POSITION AND ENGAGEMENT
India has denied the allegations under the forced labour clause. India has asked the U.S. to end the investigations. India believes such matters should be addressed within the framework of ongoing bilateral trade negotiations. India remains committed to fair labour practices and responsible trade.

HOW THE PROPOSED ADDITIONAL DUTIES APPLY

- 12.5% ADDITIONAL DUTY**
For all economies that:
• Do not impose a prohibition on the importation of goods produced with forced labour, and
• Do not have an effective partial regime.
- 10% ADDITIONAL DUTY**
For economies that:
• Impose a prohibition; or
• Have committed to impose and enforce such a prohibition through an Agreement on Reciprocal Trade; or
• Have imposed a partial regime with the effect of preventing the importation of certain forced labour goods.

TEXTILE MECHANISM (PROPOSED)
A textile mechanism would allow a certain volume of apparel & textile imports from certain economies to enter the U.S. at a reduced tariff rate.

KEY INDIAN EXPORT SECTORS POTENTIALLY IMPACTED
Textiles & Apparel, Engineering Goods, Chemicals & Pharmaceuticals, Leather & Footwear, Gems & Jewellery, Agri-foods.

POTENTIAL IMPACT ON GLOBAL TRADE
Increased costs for importers and consumers. Trade diversion and supply chain realignment. Pressure on countries to strengthen labour laws. Potential disputes in multilateral forums.

THE BIG PICTURE
This proposed action reflects the U.S. commitment to responsible trade, human rights, and level playing field for workers and businesses.

WHAT IS FORCED LABOUR?
Work or services extracted from any person under the menace of any penalty and for which the person has not offered himself voluntarily.

HAVE YOUR SAY
Request to appear & submit comments. Written comments deadline. Public hearings.

duties on all goods barring a few. A special mechanism has also been proposed for textile and apparel products that could allow a certain volume of imports from selected economies to enter the US at lower tariff rates.

The 12.5 per cent duty has been proposed on 54 countries including Argentina, Australia, Bangladesh, Brazil, Cambodia, China, India, Israel, Japan, Malaysia, New Zealand, Norway, Oman, Philippines, Qatar, Russia, Saudi Arabia, Singapore, South Africa, South Korea, Sri Lanka, Switzerland, Thailand, the UAE, the UK, and Vietnam.

A 10 per cent additional import duty has been proposed on six nations - Canada, Ecuador, the European Union, Indonesia, Mexico, and Pakistan.

The USTR statement said that it has determined that the acts, policies, and practices of

these 60 economies related to the failure to impose and effectively enforce a prohibition on the importation of goods produced with forced labour are unreasonable and burden or restrict US commerce, and are thus actionable under the provision.

“The failure of our most important trading partners to address the importation of goods made with forced labour is unacceptable. This creates a dynamic where American workers are forced to compete globally on an unlevel playing field, US Trade Representative Ambassador Jamieson Greer said in a statement.

“We will no longer tolerate this disparity,” he said.

Interested parties can submit requests to appear at hearings and summaries of testimony by June 22, 2026, while written comments are due by July 6 on the proposed

action. The USTR is scheduled to hold hearings on July 7. A final decision is expected potentially before the expiry of the temporary Section 122 tariffs (10 per cent) on July 24.

Greer said though some trading partners have taken initial steps to prevent the importation of forced labour goods, including through USMCA (US-Mexico-Canada Agreement) and commitments in Agreements on Reciprocal Trade, “each of our trading partners must do more to ensure that trade does not perversely encourage and entrench forced labour globally”.

In its submissions to the USTR on the probe, India has denied the allegations under the forced labour clause and asked the US to end the investigations, saying such matters should be addressed within the framework of ongoing bilateral trade negotiations.

NEW DELHI TALKS

The USTR proposal comes amid the three-day talks underway in Delhi to finalise the first tranche of the bilateral trade agreement (BTA) between the two countries. The US team is led by its chief negotiator Brendan Lynch. India’s chief negotiator is Darpan Jain, an additional secretary in the Department of Commerce.

On February 7, India and the US issued a joint statement finalising the contours or framework of the first phase of the BTA or an interim trade deal.

According to the framework, the US agreed to reduce tariffs on India to 18 per cent from 50 per cent. It removed the 25 per cent tariffs on Indian goods for buying Russian oil and was to cut the remaining 25 per cent to 18 per cent under the pact.

But, on February 20 this

year, the US Supreme Court ruled against President Donald Trump’s sweeping reciprocal tariffs, which were imposed under the 1977 International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA).

Following that, the US President announced the imposition of 10 per cent tariffs on all countries for 150 days, starting February 24.

As the US Supreme Court has ruled against President Donald Trump’s sweeping tariffs, the US administration now has the option of using the Section 301 investigation mechanism to impose new tariffs. The US was the second-largest trading partner of India in 2025-26.

India’s outbound shipments to the US grew marginally 0.92 per cent to USD 87.3 billion during the last fiscal year, while imports increased 15.95 per cent to USD 52.9 billion. (PTI)

Domestic demand drive India’s growth despite challenges: HUL

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Hindustan Unilever Ltd (HUL) remains confident about India’s long-term growth prospects despite near-term economic challenges, with the FMCG major betting on rising consumption, premiumisation and digital transformation to drive future growth, Chairman NitinParanjpe said.

Acknowledging that the near-term environment will continue to present challenges, Paranjpe while addressing the shareholders, said, “India has consistently demonstrated resilience, emerging stronger through periods of uncertainty”.

“For HUL, with deep roots in the country, we will navigate this environment with

agility and discipline - anchored in our unwavering commitment to serve our consumers,” he said in the latest annual report.

Paranjpe said HUL, which owns popular brands as Surf excel, Dove, Horlicks, Lifebuoy, Lakme, and Brooke Bond and reaches 9 out of 10 Indian households, is investing decisively in its future, reimagining its business with the consumer at the centre. It is strengthening its port-

folio and route-to-market capabilities while embedding technology across operations. “Our strategic investments in digital-first, science-led brands reflect our ambition to build future growth engines in premium beauty, health and wellbeing,” he said.

Technology and data analytics are playing a central role in the company’s transformation, with advanced analytics and artificial intelligence being deployed across the

value chain, from personalised consumer engagement to building a more responsive supply chain, he said.

“We remain equally committed to building future-ready talent underpinned by a culture of ownership, learning and adaptability. Together, these capabilities will power HUL’s long-term growth,” said Paranjpe.

Highlighting India’s economic momentum, Paranjpe said economic progress in recent years has been encouraging.

“Our GDP continues to grow among the fastest globally, supported by structural reforms and a policy environment that fosters investment and enterprise,” he said. He identified three key structural drivers supporting India’s growth trajectory.

RBI denies gold sale rumours; holds 880.52 tonnes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Debunking reports of gold sale, the Reserve Bank of India on Wednesday said there is no change in the physical stock of gold, which remains unchanged at 880.52 tonnes.

The clarification from the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) comes following reports that the RBI may have sold gold amounting to approximately USD 12 billion to shield its foreign-currency reserves from the impact of the ongoing conflict in West Asia.

RBI emphasises that these reports are not correct,” the central bank said in a statement.

Members of the public are, there-

fore, advised to rely on official information published by the RBI from time to time in such matters, it said.

According to RBI, the share of gold in India’s foreign exchange reserves rose from 13.92 per cent at the end of September 2025 to 16.70 per cent on March 31, 2026, and further to 16.85 per cent as of May 22, 2026, it said.

As on March 31, 2026, total gold held by the Reserve Bank was 880.52 metric tonnes as compared to 879.58 metric tonnes as on March 31, 2025, an increase of 0.94 metric tonnes of gold in the year.

“Of the 880.52 metric tonnes, 312.32 metric tonnes of gold is held as an asset of the Issue Department as compared to 311.38 metric tonnes as on March 31, 2025,” RBI in its latest annual report said. The remaining 568.20 metric tonnes, same as on March 31, 2025, is treated as an asset of the Banking Department, it said.

“The value of gold (including gold deposits) held as an asset of Banking Department increased by 63.6 per cent from ₹4,31,624.80 crore as on March 31, 2025, to ₹7,06,162.36 crore as on March 31, 2026,” it said.

Rate pause by RBI will support growth stability: SBI Chairman

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

State Bank of India chairman CS Setty on Wednesday said the economic growth process will stabilise if the RBI opts for a status quo in policy rates amid inflation challenges. Speaking at the Citi 2026 India Conference, Setty said market expectations broadly point towards a pause in rates.

“Growth and inflation dynamics are more important. I think a pause will definitely help us to stabilise in terms of ensuring that smooth growth rates are

achieved,” he said.

A majority of 11 of the 15 respondents in a PTI poll of economists and treasury participants are expecting the RBI to continue with the status quo on rates.

Most of the respondents expect the central bank to resume policy tightening

later in FY27 amid mounting inflation risks.

When asked about the proposed initial public offering (IPO) of SBI Funds Management, Setty said the company is targeting a listing during the current calendar year. “We hope to do it sometime during this year. We are just waiting for the report,” he said.

He further said SBI Funds Management has already filed its draft papers and is awaiting regulatory approvals. “We have already filed the DRHP... we are waiting for the approval,” he said.

Indian firms move from AI experimenting to core integration

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The USD 300 billion Indian IT services industry is witnessing a definitive shift from experimental AI projects to full-scale enterprise integration, with top firms deploying autonomous AI agents across their workforces, fundamentally altering business operations. Top IT firms — TCS, Infosys and Wipro — have collectively expanded their use of Microsoft 365 Copilot to over three lakh employees within just six months, according to data shared by US tech giant. The deployment scale by the Indian IT majors places them among the largest enterprise AI rollouts globally, reflecting a worldwide trend that extends across various AI models and platforms.

Accenture, which has a significant chunk of its global workforce in India, is in the process of rolling out the Copilot to hundreds of thousands of its employees, mirroring the worldwide enterprise trend where companies are moving past pilot phases to integrate AI into their core operational fabric.

Instead of utilising AI merely as a standalone tool, companies are redesigning workflows around human-agent teams. Global data from Microsoft’s Work Trend Index 2026 indicates that 49 per cent of such AI usage is now directed at cognitive tasks like analysis and problem-solving, moving beyond basic automation. TCS Chief Executive Officer and Managing Director K Krithivasan stated that embedding agentic AI into the flow of work is redefining how employees operate.

“At TCS, we have empowered over 1,00,000 associates with Microsoft 365 Copilot to enhance everyday productivity, elevate collaboration and drive intelligence-led decision-making,” he said.

Copy of the route alignment is available to the office of the contact person. Notice is hereby given to the general public to make observation / representation on the proposed transmission system within two months from the date of publication of this notice to the office of the contact person details given below in writing. For further particulars and clarifications please contact:

ASSOCIATED PRESS
 Dubai

Kuwait briefly shut its main airport on Wednesday after Iranian drones heavily damaged a terminal building, killed one person and wounded dozens — the latest in back-and-forth attacks by Tehran and Washington that have tested a fragile ceasefire.

Semiofficial Iranian news agencies have said Tehran had stopped communicating with mediators about extending the ceasefire in the war with the US and Israel.

A regional official said Iran wanted a separate ceasefire in Lebanon enforced before returning to talks. US President Donald Trump asserted that negotiations continued. The talks have dragged on for weeks, and exchanges of strikes in the Gulf region and Israel's broadening war with the Iranian-backed Hezbollah in Lebanon are further strains.

Iran maintains its hold on the Strait of Hormuz — a crucial waterway for the world's oil and natural gas and related products like fertilizer — and the US continues its blockade of Iranian ports. Global fuel prices remain high, and the effects of the conflict are felt well

**KAREEM CHEHAYEB/
JOSH BOAK**
Beirut

President Donald Trump in an interview released Wednesday confirmed an earlier report that he criticized Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu as “crazy” in a Monday phone call, saying he was “a little bit perturbed” that Israel’s fighting of Hezbollah in Lebanon was holding back peace talks with Iran.

But even as the US president acknowledged the tensions, he insisted that his relationship with Netanyahu was solid and they connected, in part, because they're both "wartime" leaders. "We've worked very well

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
Islamabad

Chinese ambassador Jiang Zaidong on Wednesday called on Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, who stressed the need to follow up on decisions made during his recent visit to China.

The premier paid a four-day official trip to China from May 23 to 26 during which he met top Chinese leaders and the two sides signed several MoUs and agreements to deepen their relations.

Jiang called on PM Shehbaz in the presence of the PM's Adviser Tauqir Shah,

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ London

Britain's Royal Navy said on Tuesday that three of its members died in a helicopter crash earlier in south India during a training exercise.

The helicopter went down in the county of Devon in 1981 before 4 am.

The navy's head General C said in a statement that he saddened to share the news crewmembers onboard a Merlin Mk4 helicopter have crashed in the early hours of near Sourton, Devon."

He said an investigation and further updates will be provided. It wasn't immediately clear what the incident. Merlin helicopters, the Merlin Mk4 involved in the crash, usually have a crew of four and can carry up to 24 troops. The Merlin is primarily used for anti-submarine warfare and is used for search and rescue, transfers and maritime patrol.

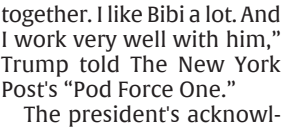


news agencies, both believed to be close to the Guard, on Tuesday reported that Iran's negotiators have stopped communicating with ceasefire mediators as tensions flare in Israel's separate but related fight against Hezbollah in Lebanon.

A regional official involved in the mediation, speaking on condition of anonymity to discuss the talks, told The Associated Press that Iran had not communicated on Tuesday after saying a

ceasefire needed to be enforced in Lebanon for negotiations to continue.

Trump called reports of a cessation in talks “false and erroneous.”



“The conversations between us have been going on continuously, including four days ago, three days ago, two days ago, one day ago and today,” Trump said in a social media post Tuesday.

Israeli forces have moved deeper into Lebanon than at any time in over a quarter-century, while Hezbollah has launched rocket and drone attacks. The declared ceasefire in Lebanon is officially in place and no side has formally withdrawn or declared it over even as attacks continue.

Lebanon has emerged as a sticking point in Trump's efforts to sign a ceasefire

deal with Iran. Tehran insists that any larger potential truce must quell the

fighting in Lebanon. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu wants to keep the issues separate and is under domestic pressure to strike Hezbollah as he prepares for elections this fall.

The fighting has exposed a rift between close allies Israel and the US, with the US pushing for restraint.

In a podcast interview released Wednesday, Trump confirmed a report that he had called Netanyahu “crazy” Monday in a phone call peppered with an expletive.

Trump told The New York Post's "Pod Force One" that he was "a little bit perturbed" that Israel's fight with Hezbollah was holding back talks with Iran.

as higher energy prices and economic uncertainty are harming Republicans going into midterm elections and hampering global commerce. But Trump remained noncommittal about a timeline for settling the conflict, saying the Strait of Hormuz might stay blocked through the Labor Day holiday on September 7.

He has insisted that Iran stop any efforts that could lead to a nuclear weapon and that the strait be reopened for the shipments of oil and natural gas. "I don't know," he said. "I mean, I think it could be resolved (closed through Labor Day), but I think it's unlikely. I think it will take more time. I think that we'll have it. I think this will resolve itself fairly quickly," Trump said. (AP)

ASSOCIATED PRESS
 Naivasha

Kenyan detectives on Wednesday were granted 21 days to hold nine students suspected of planning and executing an arson attack at a girl's boarding school in central Kenya that killed 16 children, in a case that has gripped the East African nation.

A court in the town of Naivasha ruled that the girls will be remanded at a children's home to allow investigators to complete their inquiries and determine whether to bring charges.

The fire on May 28 ripped through the Utumishi Girls' School dormitory that houses 202 students. Investigators said the school matron failed to open an emergency door, forcing all students to scamper through a single doorway.

The accused girls have been in police custody for six days, during which interrogations revealed the fire was started by lighting a mattress at the dormitory's exit using a matchstick and paraffin.

Police arrested nine girls after questioning students and reviewing CCTV footage that investigators say shows some students setting a fire inside the dormitory.



Ukrainian drones hit Russian oil terminal

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kyiv

Ukrainian long-range drones struck an oil terminal in St. Petersburg and set it ablaze, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on Wednesday, as the Russian city hosted an annual international economic forum promoted by President Vladimir Putin.

The drones flew more than 1,000 kilometres (600 miles) to hit the terminal, Zelenskyy said on social media. Clouds of black smoke rose over the city's port after the attack.

Russian authorities said only that the Ukrainian drone strike targeted the city's infrastructure, without



NATO Secretary General Mark Rutte and Ukraine's President Zelenskyy walking towards a podium before a press conference in Kyiv

providing further details. The airport of St. Petersburg briefly suspended flights overnight because of the attack. Authorities also cut off mobile internet services. Putin is set to speak on Friday at the economic forum in St. Petersburg that

the Kremlin views as a prestige event, although major Western investors and officials have stayed away since Russia invaded Ukraine more than four years ago. Saudi Arabia is a special guest country this year and is due to send a

large business delegation.

The strikes are an embarrassment for Putin, weeks after he had to prune back an annual Victory Day parade in Moscow due to fears of Ukrainian drone attacks. The strikes came a day after Russian forces launched a massive drone and missile attack on Kyiv and other Ukrainian cities, killing at least 22 civilians and wounding 138, as Moscow followed through with its threat of escalating its regular barrages.

With the front line changing little as swarms of drones hinder battlefield movement, both sides have sought an edge by increasingly launching long-range strikes. The war that fol-

lowed Russia's invasion of its neighbour has now stretched into its fifth year, with no end in sight.

Ukraine's attacks are aimed at diminishing Russia's oil production, which is a key source of funding for Moscow, and disrupting weapon production. Ukraine has repeatedly targeted oil facilities at the port of St. Petersburg and nearby ports.

Ukrainian drone attacks overnight also hit the Kronstadt naval base, an old base for Russia's Baltic Fleet, and a manufacturing plant involved in weapon production in Russia's Tambov region, 600 kilometres (370 miles) from Ukraine, Zelenskyy said.

Italy arrest two in attack on four farm workers

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Rome

Italian police have arrested two people accused in the deaths of four migrant farm-workers who were burned alive in a car, a gruesome attack captured on video surveillance cameras, police and news reports said.

According to the video, which was broadcast Tuesday on RAI state television and other Italian media, assailants, arrested on Tuesday, poured liquid into the back of the car and set it ablaze as it was parked at a gas station in Amendolara, near Cosenza in the southern Calabria region, RAI said.

One of the apparent assailants was then seen trying to keep the doors of the car closed. One man escaped from the car and was treated for burns at a nearby hospital, RAI said.

Castrovillari Prosecutor Alessandro D'Alessio confirmed in a statement that the bodies of four people were found dead in a car on Monday in Amendolara and that two people had been detained in connection with their deaths.



Sikh man's murder trial sparks protests in UK

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

A British Sikh man's conviction for the murder of a teenager triggered violent clashes targeted at the police in the UK, after body-worn camera footage showed officers handcuffing the victim in his final moments over an allegation of racism.

Large crowds descended upon Southampton on Tuesday evening as officers from the Hampshire and Isle of Wight Constabulary lined up in riot protection gear near the home of Vickrum Digwa, sentenced to life imprisonment for stabbing 18-year-old Henry Nowak to death.

They were pelted with stones and bottles as the protesters heard from anti-



immigration activists, who condemned so-called "two-tier policing" or prioritising one community over another. The force's chief constable, Alexis Boon, said 11 officers and a police dog sustained injuries during the clashes, which sparked "fear and division" in the community.

"There can be no justifica-

tion for hijacking this tragedy to stir up violence and disorder. Those responsible can expect to face the full force of the law," said UK Home Secretary Shabana Mahmood.

She echoed Prime Minister Keir Starmer's appeal from Downing Street to heed the Nowak family's powerful call to not allow

the killing to "create further division, hatred or tension" and allow the Independent Office for Police Conduct (IOPC) investigation into the actions of the police officers at the scene of the crime to be completed.

There are concerns that the issue is being seized upon by far-right groups such as Reform UK and Restore Britain for electoral gains in a key by-election in Makerfield, northern England, later this month.

The trial has also brought scrutiny over the Sikh community's legal dispensation to carry the ceremonial dagger or kirpan, after Digwa used self-defence as an argument in court over the use of a 21-cm knife he carried for religious reasons.

(PTI)

BNP, Jamaat Governments involved in Hadi's murder, claims brother

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dhaka

The brother of a youth leader who was a key figure during Bangladesh's 2024 violent student-led street protests, has accused some members of the ruling BNP government, opposition Jamaat-e-Islami and advisers of the interim government of plotting his murder last year.

Sharif Osman Hadi, a staunch critic of India and also that of deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina's now disbanded Awami League, was one of the prominent leaders of the 2024 protests that toppled her government. He floated Inqilab Mancha and was contesting as an independent candidate for the parliamentary election when he was shot at during cam-



paigning on December 12 last year and died six days later. General elections were held in February this year and Tarique Rahman-led Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) won with a landslide majority replacing the interim government led by Muhammad Yunus.

Sharif Osman Hadi's elder brother Omar Hadi's accusation emerged through two Facebook posts on Tuesday night. Earlier in December last year, he had alleged that a section within the interim government plotted his brother's killing to derail the general election. In his Facebook posts, Omar Hadi claimed that "a PS (private secretary) of Amer-e-Jamaat (Jamaat chief Shafiqur Rahman) was involved in creating the ground for murdering Shaheed (martyred) Osman Hadi."

"Some advisers of the (past) interim government and lawmakers and ministers of the BNP government were directly involved in murdering Shaheed Osman Hadi," Omar Hadi wrote in the first post.

NY Senate resolves to recognise Indian Independence Day

YOSHITA SINGH ■ New York

The New York State Senate has adopted a resolution urging Governor Kathy Hochul to proclaim August 15, 2026 as India Independence Day in the state, with lawmakers recalling Mahatma Gandhi's legacy and lauding the contributions of the Indian-American community in the US. The resolution sponsored by Senator Jeremy Cooney noted that it is the custom of the state legislature to recognise official



days that are important to the cultural heritage of New York's citizens. The resolution underlined, "India's independence is enormously impor-

tant to people around the world; it marks the end of a 90-year struggle to achieve stronger civil, political, and economic rights along with self-determination."

During the discussion on the resolution, several state senators hailed India's civilisational heritage, democratic traditions, Gandhi's enduring message of peace and the growing contributions of the Indian-American community in New York and across the US. Cooney said Indians around the world were making lasting impacts in their communities, and this is an opportunity to join together and celebrate and reflect on the shared history, culture, and heritage.

(PTI)

Over two lakh applicants paid \$1,00,000 each for H-1B visas: Mullin

SAGAR KULKARNI ■ Washington

More than two lakh applicants opted to pay \$1,00,000 for their H-1B visas to work in the US in the fiscal year 2026, Markwayne Mullin, Secretary, Department of Homeland Security (DHS), said.

Testifying before the Senate Appropriations Subcommittee on Tuesday, Mullin said the DHS had received about 2.86 lakh H-1B applications in the fiscal year 2026.

"We had 286,000 applicants a year to date for the H-1B visas, out of those, over 200,000 of them paid \$100,000 to be able to come in because it allows us to process them in a little bit faster of a manner,"



Markwayne Mullin, Secretary, Department of Homeland Security (DHS)

Mullin said in response to a question by US Senator Susan Collins on the shortage of doctors in rural parts of the country.

Mullin said applicants paying \$100,000 get their papers processed in about 15 days and it takes about 7.5 months to process other applications.

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER PHE (WATER), ASSAM CUM
ADDITIONAL MISSION DIRECTOR, JAL JEEVAN MISSION, ASSAM HENGARBARI, GUWAIATI - 781036

SHORT NOTICE RE-INVITING REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL (RFP) No. 02 of 2026-27

e-Tenders are re-invited from eligible agencies for "REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL FOR RATE CONTRACT FOR CALIBRATION OF GLASSWARE AND INSTRUMENTS FOR DIFFERENT WATER TESTING LABORATORIES UNDER JAL JEEVAN MISSION, ASSAM". An amount of Rs. 25,000.00 (Rupees Twenty Five Thousand only) is to be submitted as Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) / Bid Security. The tender documents can be downloaded from www.assamtenders.gov.in from 05.06.2026 (10:00 hours).

a) A pre-bid meeting is scheduled on 10.06.2026 at 16:00 hours. Address for the meeting is O/o Chief Engineer (PHE) Water Assam, Hengrabari, Guwahati-36. The bidders shall e-mail their queries to etenderphe@gmail.com on or before 16:00 Hrs. of 10.06.2026.

b) The last date of submission of tender document is 23.06.2026 at 16:00 hrs.

c) The bid will be opened online on the e-procurement portal on 24.06.2026 at 15:00 Hr.

The tender inviting authority reserves the right to accept or reject any bid/ tender, and to cancel/ annul the bidding process and reject all bids at any time prior to contract award.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer (PHE), Water, Assam, Cum
Addl. Mission Director, JJM Assam Hengrabari, Guwahati - 36.

DIPRC/PIO/76/4-Jun-26

PUBLIC NOTICE
Known to all that my client **Mrs. Shivani Singh W/o Ntin** who is purchasing Flat No.C- 302, Third Floor, Area 75 Sq. Yds., Property No. WZ-13/1, Old Plot No.WZ-10/1A and WZ-10, Kharsa No.92/7/3, Shri Nagar, Gali No.16, Palam Colony, Village Palam, Delhi from Mr. Anil Sharma who is the owner of the subject property by virtue of Two Gift deed dated 14.01.2010 (Doc. No.11240) and Gift Deed dated 23.11.2009 (Doc. No.9834) that the both the Gift Deed dated 14.01.2010 vide Doc. No.11240 and Gift Deed dated 23.11.2009 (Vide Doc. No.9834) have been Lost and not available. And it is informed that any deal with said documents by any person except my said client, shall be deemed as null and void. If any person having any claim/right in said property then he may contact and handover the same and apprise his claim to undersigned within 15 days of this publication.

AD REM LEGAL SOLUTION
Ch. No. 760 - Dwarka Court Sector-10, Dwarka, New Delhi-75
Mobile :- 9899013918

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of **Shri Dilpreet Singh** who is Purchasing of Upper Ground Floor without roof/terrace right towards back side of built up property bearing Plot No. W2-90, measuring 100 sq. yds. i.e. 83.61 sq. mtr., out of Kharsa No. 89/23, situated in the revenue estate of Village Kestla, Delhi State, Delhi, area abated known as colony South Extn., Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059 (hereinafter called the subject property) from Smt. Preeti Kumar who became the owner through Relinquishment. Died dated 30/12/2025 duly registered in the office of SR-West Janakpuri Delhi as registration No. 2025/25136642, Addl. Book No. Page No. 11-20, Volume No. 16820, dated 30/12/2025, now Shri Dilpreet Singh intend to purchase and mortgage the subject property for the financial assistance from ADITYA BIRLA HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED That Original Sale Deed dated 15/11/2016 duly registered in the office of SR-II-B, West Janakpuri Delhi as registration No. 18898, Addl. Book No. 1, Page No. 128-137, Volume No. 5397, dated 15/11/2016, has been lost/misplaced/not available). FIR already lodged vide LR No. 336248/2026 dated 29/05/2026 to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucern Legal LLP, N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Saraf Community Centre, New Delhi-110049 Contact# 011-40046316 & 41687327

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform the general public that Mr. Jitender Kumar is the owner of Residential Vacant Plot No. 247, area measuring 450.00 Sq. Mtrs situated in Block-B, sector-50, Noida; Gautam Budh Nagar (U.P.) through Transfer Deed of Lease hold rights dated 11.10.2002 as doc. no. 3010-11 executed by Mr. Dev Karan through his lawful wife, Mrs. Laxmi Devi in favour of Jitender Kumar in respect of residential Vacant Plot No. 247, area measuring 450.00 Sq. Mtrs. Unfortunately, Mr. Jitender Kumar had died on 28.03.2025 and as per SMC shared with us of Mr. Jitender Kumar leaving behind his lawful wife, Mrs. Laxmi Devi in favour of Jitender Kumar (wife) (2) Mr. Gaurav (Son) (3) Mr. Saurav (Son) (4) Ms. Anshul (Daughter). He had earlier executed Will dated 01.05.1998 executed by Mr. Jitender Kumar in favour of his wife Mrs. Laxmi Devi in respect of Plot No. 247, area measuring 450.00 Sq. Mtrs in respect of moveable Property and Immovable Property (hereinafter North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 31, 3rd Floor, Building No. A-4/A, Sector-26, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201302; Landline: 01202-04699711, e-mail: accounts@northindia

NORTHERN RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE
No. 570-SIG-PS-Tender-144
Dy. CSTE/C/PS/NDS, Northern Railway, New Delhi for and on behalf of the President of India invites open e-tender (Single Packet System) for the following work:-

1) Name of work & Place	Provision of Automatic Fire Suppression System at Bijwasan station of DLI Division of Northern Railway.
2) Completion period	03 Months from the date of issue of LOA
3) Approx. cost	Rs. 67.12 Lacs (Approx)
4) Earnest money amount	Rs. 134300/- (Rupees One Lakh Thirty Four Thousand Three Hundred only)
5) Sale/availability of tender document on Rly. website	Tender documents will be available on IREPS web site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in from 03.06.2026 to 25.06.2026 upto 11.30 hrs.
6) Last date/Time of upload of tenders	25.06.2026 upto 11.30 hours. Tender documents can be uploaded by the tenderer on IREPS web site w.e.f. 11.06.2026 to 25.06.2026.
7) Date of opening of tender	25.06.2026 at 11.30 hours (Technical cum financial bid shall be opened immediately after close of uploading of tender.)

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE
1886/26

US police negotiate Bakersfield hostage standoff at Chase bank



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Bakersfield

Police were locked in negotiations with a man holding hostages inside a building that houses a Chase bank branch and school district office in the Southern California city of Bakersfield, officials said. Officers responding to a call of a bomb threat arrived at the scene around 1 pm Tuesday night at the Chase Bank building in downtown Bakersfield, and discovered that a man had barricaded himself inside "with several community members", the Bakersfield Police Department said in a statement. Through negotiations, two of the hostages were released and the rest are in "good health," city police Sgt Eric Celedon

said. "We have every single resource at our disposal out here to bring this to the safest resolution possible," he said.

Nearby buildings were evacuated, including city hall and the police headquarters, and some roads were temporarily closed, according to officials. Officers established a perimeter around the building and nearby businesses, authorities said. Celedon warned the public to stay out of the area, explaining that this is still a very active situation. A spokesperson for JPMorgan Chase said its branch is on the ground floor of the building and is currently empty. The company is working with authorities. The department's crisis negotiation team was in contact with the suspect by telephone.

कार्यालय नगर पालिक निगम, भोपाल
(विद्युत शाखा)
समान तल, नवीन मुख्यालय भवन, तुलसी नगर, सेकण्ड स्टॉप, भोपाल - 462003
दिनांक-02.06.2026
क्रमांक 38 & 39/वि.शा./2026
निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु दो लिफाफा पद्धति के अनुसार मोहरबंद निविदाएं निर्धारित प्रपत्र पर आनलाईन आमंत्रित की जाती है।

क्र.	ऑनलाईन निविदा क्र.	कार्य का विवरण	अनुमानित राशि	घरोंर राशि	निविदा प्रपत्र की कीमत	टेकदार की श्रेणी	कार्य हेतु निर्धारित एस्.ओ.आर.	कार्य की अवधि
1	2026 UAD 512311.1	Laighati Sub-station Shifting work	1004578/-	2,70,433/-	20,000/-	Registered Electrical contractor in centralized registration system in MPPWD having valid electrical license	MPUADDOR Works, 2021 MPPWD SOR-2024 and MPMAVVCCL MPCZ SOR 2025	06 Months
2	2026 UAD 512322.1	Comprehensive maintenance of 06 nos Passenger Lift for (03 years) of BMC Building Bhopal	1550370/-	19783/-	5,000/-	Registered Electrical contractor in centralized registration system in MPPWD having valid electrical license	MPUADDOR Works, 2021 MPPWD SOR-2024 and MPMAVVCCL MPCZ SOR 2025	36 Months

नियम व शर्तें :- (1). निविदा प्रपत्र की निर्धारित राशि अघोर राशि एवं अन्य आवश्यक दस्तावेज ऑनलाईन प्रस्तुत करने होंगे। अन्य समस्त विस्तृत जानकारी www.mptenders.gov.in पर देखी जा सकती है। (2). ऑनलाईन निविदा में सभी प्रकार के संशोधनों की जानकारी मात्र www.mptenders.gov.in पर प्राप्त की जा सकती है। (3). 18% GST अतिरिक्त देय होगा।

नि.क्र. -258/026/027

कार्यालय नगरी (वि.) नगर निगम, भोपाल

PUBLIC NOTICE
Known to all that my client **Mrs. Umrawati Kaur**, owner of property bearing No. 118-A, 40.00 Sq. Yds., Kharsa No. 11/10, Near Shiv Mandir Mahavir Enclave South West Delhi-110045, and My Client Purchased aforesaid property from Mr. Bansil Lal vide notarized GPA, ATS and Will dated 18.09.2002 now My Client wants to sell aforesaid property. And it is informed that any deal with said documents by any person except my said client and said institution regarding said property, shall be deemed as null and void. If any person having any claim, right in said property then he may contact and handover the same and apprise his claim to undersigned within 15 days of this publication.

AD REM LEGAL SOLUTION
Ch. No. 760 - Dwarka Court Sector-10, Dwarka, New Delhi-75
Mobile :- 9899013918

PUBLIC NOTICE
It is to inform the public at large that Mrs. Usha Sharma had acquired House No. 441, Gali No. 15, measuring 61.03 sq. mtrs., out of Kharsa No. 686, at Village Mahipal Pur Tehsil Mehrauli, New Delhi., vide Conveyance Deed (P.H. Uday) dt. 10.03.2022 executed by P.O. w.r.t. said property, doc no. 1072. Now Mrs. Usha Sharma is the undisputed owner of above said property and is willing to Mortgage the above said property with any financial institution.

PUBLIC NOTICE
It is to inform the public at large that Mrs. Usha Sharma has acquired House No. 441, Gali No. 15, measuring 61.03 sq. mtrs., out of Kharsa No. 686, at Village Mahipal Pur Tehsil Mehrauli, New Delhi., vide Conveyance Deed (P.H. Uday) dt. 10.03.2022 executed by P.O. w.r.t. said property, doc no. 1072. Now Mrs. Usha Sharma is the undisputed owner of above said property and is willing to Mortgage the above said property with any financial institution.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given that **Mrs. CHARAN Kaur**, owner of property bearing No. 130,131,132,133 total area 120' x 45' measuring 600 sq.yds. of kharsa no. 124/14 situated in revenue estate of village Dichaon Kela, nagari delhi abadi known as colony Jai Vihar, Phase-II Nangaloi Najafgarh road, expired on 25/10/2008. After her demise, her legal rights and interests in the said property devolved upon her legal heirs, including Mr. GURJEET SINGH ASST ADHAAR NO. 2756 5753 0682. It has come to notice that certain persons are claiming and/or occupying the said property without lawful authority or on disputed claims. Any person having any right, title, interest, possession, tenancy, licence, lien, mortgage, or objection in respect of the said property is hereby called upon to submit supporting documents within 15 days from publication of this notice, failing which no such claim shall be entertained thereafter. General public is cautioned not to enter into any transaction regarding the said property without due verification from the lawful legal heir(s), failing which they shall do so at their own risk and consequences.

Mridul Arora (Advocate), Juris Associates & Solicitors, Mob: 9667055391

NORTHERN RAILWAY
CORRIGENDUM
Ref: i) Tender Notice No.72/2025-2026 dated 16/12/2025 (Sr. No. 08)
ii) Tender No.15225019B due on 09/07/2026.
01. In reference to above tender, the due date has been extended from 09/06/2026 to 09/07/2026. All other terms & conditions remain unchanged.
The Corrigendum has been published on website www.ireps.gov.in.
1889/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

मध्यप्रदेश पुलिस आवास एवं अधोसंरचना विकास निगम
कार्यालय परियोजना जरी, इन्दौर संभाग क्र.1
जी-13, प्रथम तल, एम.आई.जी. कॉलोनी, क्रिश्चियन एमीनेंट स्कूल के पीछे, इंदौर, दूरभाष : 9425601533
निविदा सूचना क्र. 05/2026-27

मध्यप्रदेश पुलिस आवास एवं अधोसंरचना विकास निगम, इन्दौर संभाग क्र. 1, इन्दौर द्वारा मुख्यमंत्री पुलिस आवास योजना (तृतीय चरण) के अंतर्गत 48 एन.जी.ओ. एवं 192 अरसरक (S+12) बहुमंजिला आवास गृहों का निर्माण कार्य, 15वीं वाहिनी, वि.स. बल, इन्दौर अनुमानित लागत रु. 55.04 करोड़ हेतु निविदा (क्र. 2026_MPPHC_512350) आमंत्रित की गई है। विस्तृत निविदा सूचना एवं अन्य विवरण Portal : <https://www.mptenders.gov.in> पर देखे जा सकते हैं।

म.प्र. माध्यम/126150/2026 परियोजना जरी

Assam CM meets President Murmu, seeks guidance for State’s development journey

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Wednesday called on President Droupadi Murmu and briefed her on the state’s rapid economic growth and future development roadmap.

The meeting assumes significance as it was Sarma’s first meeting with the President after assuming office as Chief Minister for a second consecutive term.

Sharing details of the meeting on social media platform X, Sarma described the President as an “epitome of courage, resilience and leadership” and said that interacting with her is always an inspiring experience.

“Meeting Hon’ble President



Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma meeting with President Droupadi Murmu in New Delhi on Wednesday

PIONEER PHOTO

is always an inspiring experience and her words act as an encouragement in our path of public service,” the Chief Minister wrote.

During the meeting,

Sarma apprised the President of Assam’s ongoing growth journey and the government’s plans to sustain the momentum in the coming years.

“After assuming office for the second time, I briefed her on Assam’s ongoing growth journey as India’s fastest-growing state and how we plan to take this momentum forward,” he said.

The Chief Minister also sought the President’s blessings and guidance as his government continues to focus on public welfare, infrastructure expansion and economic development.

“I sought her blessings and guidance to continue our journey of public welfare and development,” Sarma added.

The meeting comes as the Assam government pushes ahead with initiatives aimed at strengthening economic growth, attracting investments and improving public services across the State.

NCC cadets complete training camp at Nalbari

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

The Combined Annual Training Camp (CATC)-34 conducted by 1 Assam Battalion NCC under the Guwahati Group concluded successfully at Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya, Nalbari.

The ten-day camp, held from May 23 to June 1, 2026, brought together 520 NCC cadets, including boys and girls from both Senior and Junior Divisions, representing schools and colleges across Guwahati, Nalbari, Rangia and Tamulpur.

The camp aimed to impart basic military training while fostering leadership, discipline, character and a spirit of selfless service among the youth.

During the camp, cadets underwent intensive training in drill, weapon han-



dling, map reading and firing practice.

A series of special lectures was also organised on leadership, national integration and social service to enhance the cadets’ knowledge and awareness of contemporary issues.

Career guidance sessions were conducted by the

Army Recruitment Office (ARO), Narangi, and faculty members from Assam Skill University.

A major highlight of the camp was the visit of Brig NC Khuman, Group Commander, Guwahati Group, on May 27.

During his visit, he reviewed the training activ-

ities, interacted with cadets and staff, and underscored the important role of the National Cadet Corps in shaping disciplined, responsible and patriotic citizens.

The camp concluded with a ceremonial closing function presided over by the Camp Commandant.

Prizes were awarded to outstanding cadets as well as winning schools and colleges for their exceptional performance in various training and competitive events.

The successful completion of CATC-34 marked another significant step by the NCC in nurturing future leaders and responsible citizens of Assam through transformative training and value-based education imparted by the NCC Guwahati Group under the NER Directorate.

PROSPECT Corteva introduces Mavilon for pest management in rice

Corteva has introduced Mavilon, a granular insecticide for pest management in rice in India. Corteva unveiled the product at a launch event in Hyderabad, where CEO Chuck Magro joined customers, channel partners, and key stakeholders to mark the occasion.

Rice in India is a daily staple central to the agri economy. Yet across rice-growing regions, farmers face a persistent and costly threat. Pests like Brown Planthopper (BPH) and stem borer cause crop stress, yield loss, and reduced grain quality. Most farmers manage these pests reactively, spraying only after infestation is visible. This approach has real limitations. Delayed detection means damage is often already underway before action is taken. Labor shortages at peak periods, combined with dependence on rain-free windows, add further operational uncertainty at critical moments in the crop cycle.

Applied once at 30-35 days after transplanting, Mavilon begins protecting the crop before visible damage occurs. Its innovative granular formulation delivers up to 60 days of control against BPH and up to 15 days against stem borer. This helps safeguard the crop through its most yield-critical phases. By intervening early, Mavilon™ helps farmers stay ahead of pest pressure rather than responding to it.



Nagaland BJP President Benjamin Yephthomi attending the declaration programme of the BJP Nagaland candidate for the ULB By-Election Kezhangtso Zhotso, in the presence of Minister Mr Jacob Zhimomi, Adviser Mr H Tovihoto Ayemi and other party officials

Prohibitory order issued on river activities during monsoon season in Kamrup

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amingaon

In view of the rising water levels in the Brahmaputra and its tributaries due to continuous rainfall during the ongoing monsoon season, Kamrup District Magistrate Deba Kumar Mishra has issued a prohibitory order under Section 30 of the Disaster Management Act, 2005, to prevent loss of life and ensure public safety.

The order has been issued considering the heightened risks posed by strong river currents, sudden rises in water levels, riverbank erosion and submerged hazards.

The administration has also taken note of recurring incidents of drowning and other water-related accidents during the monsoon season.

As per the order, bathing, swimming, diving, or entering the waters of all rivers within Kamrup district, including the Brahmaputra and its tributaries, is strictly prohibited until further orders.

The public has also been directed to refrain from undertaking any activity that may expose themselves or



Kamrup district Magistrate Deba Kumar Mishra, ACS

others to the risk of drowning or river-related accidents.

The Police Department, Revenue officials, Response Agencies and other concerned authorities have been instructed to monitor vulnerable river ghats and locations and ensure strict enforcement of the order.

Any person found violating the order shall be liable for action under the relevant provisions of the Disaster Management Act, 2005, and other applicable laws.

The District Magistrate has urged all residents to exercise utmost caution and cooperate with the authorities in safeguarding lives during the monsoon season.

Delhi CM Gupta holds public hearing, orders swift action on civic grievances

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday held a public hearing at the Chief Minister’s Jan Seva Sadan, where she directly interacted with residents from across the Capital and instructed officials to act swiftly on complaints related to civic services, education, social welfare, and law enforcement.

The programme saw a large number of people arriving with personal and administrative grievances, ranging from pending municipal issues to education-related hardships and family disputes.

The Chief Minister said the initiative was aimed not only at resolving complaints but also at improving accountability and trust between the government and citizens.

Officials from several departments, including the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, police, revenue, education, and social welfare, were directed to review the complaints and ensure timely action.

The Chief Minister personally heard several cases and sought updates from the concerned authorities during



the proceedings.

One of the key issues raised during the hearing concerned pending civic matters linked to the Municipal Corporation.

Residents complained about unresolved local problems and delays in administrative action.

The Chief Minister instructed officials to review all pending matters on priority and ensure that appropriate solutions were implemented without further delay.

In another case, a woman approached the Chief Minister regarding difficulties affecting her children’s education. After hearing the complaint, the Chief Minister directed officials to provide immediate assistance so that the children’s studies would not be disrupted.

The Chief Minister also

intervened in a matter involving banking issues and a family dispute after a woman sought help during the hearing.

Taking serious note of the complaint, the Chief Minister instructed the concerned authorities to extend legal and administrative support to the aggrieved woman and ensure that the matter was addressed fairly.

Speaking during the programme, the Chief Minister said governance should not remain limited to policy announcements or official files. She said the real purpose of government schemes was fulfilled only when ordinary citizens were able to access relief, justice, and public services without unnecessary hurdles.

“The government’s responsibility does not end

with launching schemes. Their benefits must reach every citizen effectively,” she said during the interaction.

The Chief Minister said the Delhi Government was committed to functioning in the spirit of Antyodaya, with a focus on reaching the last person in society.

According to her, public hearings provide the administration with direct feedback from citizens and also help identify gaps within the system. She said such interactions were important because they allowed people to place their grievances directly before the government instead of moving endlessly between departments and offices.

Officials present at the Jan Seva Sadan were instructed to maintain regular follow-up on the complaints raised during the hearing and ensure that pending matters were not allowed to remain unresolved for long periods.

The public hearing programme is part of the Delhi Government’s broader attempt to establish direct communication between citizens and the administration. Senior officials said such meetings would continue to improve service delivery and strengthen coordination between departments.

Indian Army, forest department start green drive before World Environment Day in Assam



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

In a major environmental conservation initiative ahead of World Environment Day 2026, the Red Shield Division under the Spear Corps, in collaboration with the Forest

community welfare.

As part of the initiative, a total of 10,000 saplings were planted across key locations in Tinsukia and Charaideo districts, including Tinkopani and Jagun, the Amguri area of Phillabari Reserve Forest at Rupai, and Patsaku. The activities witnessed active participation from Indian Army personnel, Territorial Army troops, Forest Department officials, ex-servicemen, NCC cadets, school students, local organisations, youth groups, civil volunteers and residents.

The plantation drives were aimed at enhancing the region’s green cover and supporting long-term environmental sustainability.

Farmer’s daughter to Asian gold: Muskan Antil felicitated



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Muskan Antil of Kheveda village, Sonipat, who won 5000m gold at the 22nd Asian Masters Athletics, was felicitated in the national capital by International Ramlila Festival Association president and social activist Dr Ved Tandon.

Muskan hails from a farming family with two acres of land. Her father Mukesh Antil and mother Kavita Devi backed both Muskan and her brother Sumit in sports despite limited resources. The siblings trained at Sonipat Stadium under coach Sandeep Sharma, who was also honoured.

Sumit’s career ended due to a knee injury and lack of funds for treatment. The family then focused on Muskan’s training.

HCL awards LOHUM 20-year deal to revive 50,000 TPA copper project in Gujarat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Greater Noida

Hindustan Copper Limited (HCL) has awarded LOHUM the rights to restart, upgrade, and maintain the 50,000 tonne-per-annum (TPA) Copper Project at Jhagadia, Gujarat, under a 20-year revenue-sharing agreement, extendable by 5 years.

The Letter of Award was presented to LOHUM by Sanjiv Kumar Singh, Chairman and Managing Director, alongside Dr. Sanjeev Kumar Sinha, Director (Operations); RVN Vishweshwar, Director (Finance); Ghanashyam Das Gupta, Director (Mining); and Harsimran Singh (Chief Vigilance Officer), Hindustan Copper Limited.

The upgraded facility will produce 99.9997 per cent



pure Grade-A copper cathodes, meeting the highest international quality standards, to serve India’s rising demand from the power, electronics, construction, and electric vehicle sectors.

Copper sits at the foundation of India’s energy future. Every megawatt of solar capacity requires approximately 3,000 kg of it; every electric vehicle on Indian roads carries around 60 to 80 kg; and a single AI data centre can consume close to

28 to 30 tonnes of copper, making India’s fast-expanding data centre sector another significant driver of demand.

With domestic demand crossing 1,878 kilotonnes in FY2025 and growing at over 9 per cent annually, restarting copper refining capacity at this scale will directly strengthen job creation, national infrastructure, technology ecosystems, and energy security.

GURU NANAK DEV UNIVERSITY, AMRITSAR SHORT TERM E-TENDER NOTICE

Short Term E-Tenders are invited for the purchase of Melt Spinning Machine, Needle Punching Non-Woven Machine, Fast Braiding Machine and Flat V Double Bed Rib Knitting be submitted online latest by 15/06/2026 upto 4:00 p.m. Detailed information can be obtained from website www.eproc.punjab.gov.in. Any corrigendum/Addendum related to these e-tender will be uploaded, if required, on Punjab Govt. website: eproc.punjab.gov.in

Director of Research

2426/12/2026-27/11925 Dated CHD :- 03/06/2026

DAILY SUDOKU

7		2			4		1
				1		5	2
		2		9	8		6
8			5	3			
	3					1	
					8	7	
							5
	9		8	1		5	
2	1		7				
4		8			5		3

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★☆☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

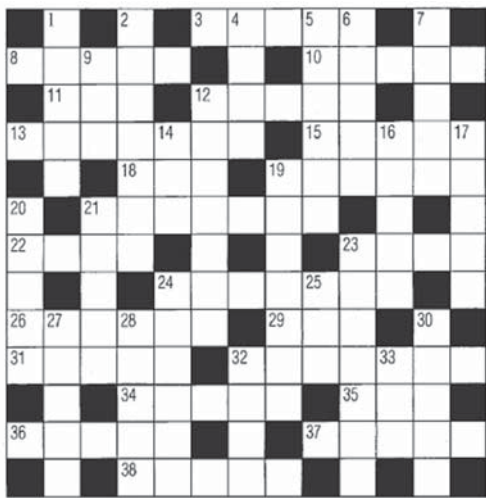
Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (3.6.26)

3	4	8	6	5	2	9	7	1
2	1	5	8	9	7	6	4	3
7	6	9	3	1	4	5	8	2
8	5	4	9	6	1	2	3	7
6	3	1	2	7	8	4	9	5
9	7	2	4	3	5	8	1	6
4	9	7	1	2	6	3	5	8
1	2	3	5	8	9	7	6	4
5	8	6	7	4	3	1	2	9

DOUBLE CROSSWORD THURSDAY | JUNE 4, 2026



ACROSS

- A sound note can mean money (5)
- Appreciate a turn with some effort (2,3)
- He greatly likes a cash surplus (5)
- One who looks, but doesn't sound, a bit of a lout (3)
- Here, in Scotland, you have to have some trousers on (5)
- What the mind does when a horse appears in trunks? (7)
- Is its thin end the western side? (5)
- Getting the bird, he finishes crestfallen (3)
- Is the back of it over there in bed? (6)
- At home, its contents may well be growing (7)
- Perform a soft song (4)

DOWN

- Mark goes ahead when an officer leads (5)
- Not strictly in a brusque manner? (7)
- They're pulled on in pairs (4)
- Seem unhappy to be a source of illumination? (6)
- Attractive individual within the confines of Holloway (5)
- Be the boss of some foreigners (5)
- Fatheaded blunder in bad weather! (3)
- Alice in Wonderland was a draw for him (7)
- Clear field? (3)
- Put out by merely half done service (5)
- He has a familiar name for a little girl (

- Drink from a plastic cup? (4)
- Hebe's upset when I have a source of sweetness (7)
- To suggest a doctor may be evil is nonsense! (6)
- Is she anticipating? (3)
- To point misshapen ears out can be wiser (5)
- A waterless loch can be the result of drought (7)
- Keeps a ship out of a certain river (5)
- She'll be back in January (3)
- The way to have very little money by the end of the month (5)
- Plant suitable for borders (5)
- A sighed utterance from an actor? (5)

- Brook providing drinks outside the church (7)
- They get a bashing at the cookhouse (5)
- Make a deposit with distress around the end of January (3,2)
- Ways for an article to upset even us! (7)
- Sailors find them accommodating (6)
- Woman going up the wall? (3)
- Smooth stuff a bright boy gets ahead with (5)
- She'll always give a chap a light (5)
- It's ordinary practice for some guys to be wise (5)
- Immersed in fluid swirling in an eddy (7)
- Possibly the deep ulterior motive (3)

SOLUTION (3.6.26)

- ACROSS

- Smash
 - Reach
 - Wide boy
 - AD-MIT
 - Me-Ca
 - P-lead
 - M-a-scar-a
 - Ho-E
 - Arch
 - School
- DOWN

- Med-lar
 - Switch
 - OAP
 - Sweater
 - Steal
 - Shoot
 - Paint
 - Alleg-Ed
 - Slope
 - Pa-use
- ACROSS

- Spice
 - G-races
 - Cite
 - 25
 - 26
 - 27
 - 28
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 - 30
 - 31
- DOWN

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BRIEFLY

Artist Wyland suing FIFA over destruction of Dallas whale mural



The artist who painted a giant mural on a building in downtown Dallas of life-sized swimming whales has filed a \$25 million lawsuit against soccer's international governing body and others, saying they illegally painted over his work to promote the city's upcoming World Cup matches.

The artist Wyland says he hand-painted the sprawling mural that covered roughly 17,000 square feet (1,580 square metres) across two of the building's walls.

The mural stood for nearly three decades before workers began painting over it last month, causing an uproar among residents who admired the mural's grand scale and message of ocean conservation. The area's World Cup organizing committee said in a statement that, in place of Wyland's mural, new artwork is planned "that captures this current historical moment and reflects the energy, unity, and global spirit surrounding the World Cup 2026."

It said a portion of Wyland's mural would be preserved. Wyland filed suit Monday in US District Court in Dallas saying that World Cup organizers, along with the building's owner and management company, painted over his mural without his consent or even notifying him. He says their actions violated a 1990 federal law passed to protect visual artists from destruction of publicly displayed works. Wyland is seeking at least \$25 million in damages. His lawsuit says world soccer's governing body, FIFA, and other defendants "hastily and irrevocably destroyed a civic landmark" to promote the World Cup.

(AP)

Afghanistan women's soccer team rises again



Fatima Yousufi escaped the Taliban, arriving in Australia with a backpack and a burning ambition to play international soccer. Through their own determination and courage, and with family support, Yousufi and others like Mona Amini had been able to study, to play soccer for clubs and for the Afghanistan women's team. But when the Taliban returned to power in 2021 it shut down all women's sports, and the players of the Afghan team went into hiding.

After a frantic evacuation, 13 of the players settled in Australia where for five years they lived, played and trained in the hope of once again being allowed to represent their country. <The Afghanistan soccer federation doesn't recognize the women's team. But in April, soccer's world governing body granted the Afghan women's team eligibility for international competition.

This week, 23 members of the Afghan Women United program are in a training camp in Auckland, New Zealand and will play games against a team from the Cook Islands.

"It was a special day that we heard that Afghanistan can represent again our flag in international tournaments," Amini, a midfielder, told The Associated Press in a Zoom call Tuesday. "This is the result of hard work that we did in the past four or five years."

Seven months ago, the Afghan women played in the so-called "Unite" tournament in which they achieved a win over Libya.

(AP)

Norway Chess: Praggnanandhaa beats Magnus Carlsen again

AJAI MASAND ■ Oslo

Young Indian Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa dealt another stunning blow to hometown hero and world No. 1 Magnus Carlsen, defeating the Norwegian in a classical game for the second time at Norway Chess 2026 and boosting his bid to become the first Indian champion of the prestigious event.

World champion D Gukesh's title hopes ended after another heavy Round 8 defeat to French Grandmaster Alireza Firouzja, leaving him bottom of the table on eight points and still unable to halt a worrying run of form since his 2024 world title triumph.

In a remarkable achievement in the elite double round-robin event, Praggnanandhaa became the only player to beat Carlsen twice in classical games this year, underlining his growing stature.

With two rounds still to play, the win pushed 20-year-old Praggnanandhaa up to third place on 12 points, with Alireza second on 13 and American GM Wesley So still leading on 14 points after an Armageddon tie-break victory over Germany's Vincent Keymer.

Carlsen's poor run of form continued, leaving his bid for an eighth Norway Chess title all but over. The five-time world champion sits on just nine points, and even two classical wins is unlikely to be enough to pull him back into contention.

Carlsen has endured an uncharacteristically turbulent campaign, suffering a third defeat overall at the hands of Praggnanandhaa, who had also beaten him once in the 2024 edition of the tournament and has now emerged as one of the strongest challengers to his long-standing dominance.

"It's more important for the tournament that I get this win than thinking that it's Magnus. Of course, it's great to do it against Magnus, but I think winning any game at this stage of the tournament is good,"



said Praggnanandhaa, who had the black pieces, after the match.

Praggnanandhaa steered the game into a queen-and-bishop endgame with an extra pawn — one that was objectively likely to end in a draw. However, he kept pressing in a position that was still more difficult for white to handle, and Carlsen eventually faltered.

"Yeah, it was an interesting game. I was putting pressure throughout, both on the clock and on the board. I thought Carlsen defended really well given the time trouble, and in the end it looked like it could be a draw. I think I've lost too many points in time trouble, so I don't mind taking some

back," he added. Asked if he was witnessing a changing of guard, Praggnanandhaa strongly rejected the notion that it has become easier to play against the five-time world champion.

"He's still very good...he has around 20 world titles, so no one is even close. I've had some good results in the past two months, but I wouldn't say it's easier to play Magnus," he said.

"He is still very strong, but in this tournament, whenever he has been under time pressure, things haven't gone his way. If you take those moments away, he's still playing well," Praggnanandhaa added.

In the ninth and penultimate round after Wednesday's rest day, Praggnanandhaa will play Black against Gukesh, who slipped to last place after his classical defeat to Alireza. Norway Chess Women witnessed

two decisive classical games and one Armageddon finish in Round 8, with Bibisara Assaubayeva strengthening her hold on the title race. The Kazakh scored a crucial classical win over Divya Deshmukh, turning the game around after the Indian ran into time trouble and collecting the full three points.

China's Zhu Jiner also notched up a classical victory, defeating reigning women's world champion Ju Wenjun to move level with Divya on 10 points.

Defending champion Anna Muzychuk and Koneru Humpy drew their classical game before another drawn Armageddon battle handed Humpy the bonus points, as she had the black pieces.

With two rounds remaining, Bibisara leads comfortably on 15.5 points, followed by Muzychuk on 10.5, while Divya and Zhu are tied on 10 points.

Results (Round 8)

Open: Alireza Firouzja (Fra, 13) bt D, Gukesh (Ind, 8); Magnus Carlsen (Nor, 9) lost to R. Praggnanandhaa (Ind, 12); Wesley So (USA, 14) bt Vincent Keymer (USA, 10).

Women: Zhu Jiner (Chn, 10) bt Ju Wenjun (Chn, 9); Divya Deshmukh (Ind, 10) lost to Bibisara Assaubayeva (Kaz, 15.5); Anna Muzychuk (Ukr, 10.5) bt Koneru Humpy (Ind, 8).

(PTT)

Gukesh is a smart player, don't see any clear weakness in his game: Sindarov

AJAI MASAND ■ Oslo

D Gukesh's prolonged form slump might be a talking point in the chess world right now but his world championship challenger Javokhir Sindarov sees no obvious weakness in the Indian's game and is fretting over his own lack of experience for their high-intensity clash this year.

The 20-year-old Uzbek beat a stacked field of seven contenders in the Candidates Tournament earlier this year to secure a clash against reigning world champion Gukesh at a yet-to-be-decided venue later this year. Speaking on the sidelines of the ongoing Norway Chess Tournament here, Sindarov said he will begin the World Championship preparations in right earnest only next month.

"I feel he is a very smart player. I played him at Tata Steel chess; he's really very strong," Sindarov said, recalling their dramatic draw in Wijk Aan Zee this year.

"I don't see any clear weakness in his game. From next month I'll start my preparations, but right now I need to focus on the



Olympiad. My team is already working on the World Championship," said Sindarov, who lost to Gukesh in rapid action at the Grand Chess Tour Super Rapid and Blitz in Poland earlier this year.

It was their first meeting since Sindarov became the world championships challenger.

Sindarov said his lack of experience in one-on-one matches —

especially in the 14-game World Championship format — weighs on his mind but he is focused on improving his game.

"Actually, I've played 6-8 matches in the men's World Cup (in Goa last year), but this classical 14-game match, I've never played before. I cannot say anything because I don't have any experience, but I know it will be very hard, and I also

know I'm very close.

"So, I'm close to winning this tournament, like Gukesh also, because the chances might be similar, so it will be a very good match. But from my side, I just want to work on my chess and play well in my next tournament and in the World Championship match too," said Sindarov, who won the World Cup in Goa for his first major international title. Sindarov said he has increased his workload, spending more than 10 hours a day in order to achieve his goals.

"From last year, I can say only one thing, that I really work a lot. I mean, even if you take how many hours I play (the) Counter-Strike (game), I really work a lot," said Sindarov.

"I

work 10 hours in one day, like probably in one year it should be more than 80-90 days...and we've really worked a lot on chess and the results are coming.

"I want to be a very strong chess player, and if I keep working in this system of putting in long hours, I believe I can become one of the strongest players in the world. There is a dream," he added.

(PTT)



Four players of Indian origin follow Vikash Dhorasoo's footsteps in FIFA World Cup

PHILEM DIPAK SINGH ■ New Delhi

Qualifying for the FIFA World Cup has remained a dream for India. But the 23rd edition in the Americas, beginning on June 11, will feature four Indian origin players.

The quartet — Sarpreet Singh, Samuel Moutoussamy, Nishan Velupillay, and Tahsin Mohammed — follow the footsteps of Vikash Dhorasoo, the French midfielder, who appeared in the 2006 World Cup in Germany.

Dhorasoo's forefathers had their roots in Vizianagaram in Andhra Pradesh. Here's a closer look at the latest entrants in that list.

Sarpreet Singh (New Zealand): Born in Auckland to Punjabi parents, Sarpreet even played in India during the Intercontinental Cup in 2018 in Mumbai. He played against the likes of Sunil Chhetri after making his NZ debut earlier that year. He was part of an U23 development side as NZ did not send the first team.

Sarpreet scored against Kenya and provided both the assists in New Zealand's 2-0 win against India.

India won the title while NZ finished third in the four-nation tournament.

One year later, Sarpreet became the first player of Indian descent to play in the German first division league when



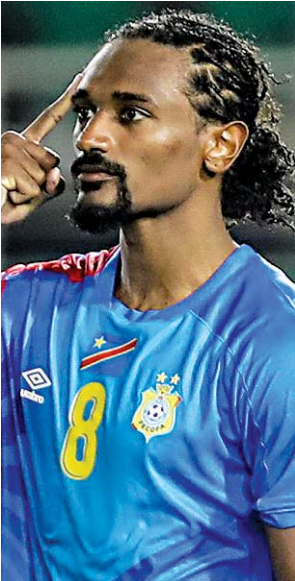
he debuted for Bayern Munich in 2019. He joined the club from Australian A-League side Wellington Phoenix. He came on as a substitute against Werder Bremen.

Initially, the 27-year-old attacking midfielder was with Bayern's reserve team in the third division, but his impressive performances earned him a first-team debut under then-manager

Hansi Flick.

Sarpreet made his first senior start for Bayern Munich on June 20, 2020, against SC Freiburg. He was part of the squad that won the Bundesliga title in 2019-2020 season.

After his stint in Germany, Sarpreet was with Uniao de Leiria in Portugal for one season before moving to Serbian SuperLiga side FK TSC in 2025.



This year, he returned to NZ, playing in the A-League for Phoenix on loan from FK TSC.

He suffered an injury in February, sidelining him for eight weeks but returned on the field in April before making the New Zealand World Cup squad of 26. He has earned 24 international caps for NZ and scored three times.

Sarpreet also played for New Zealand at the 2017 and 2019 FIFA U-20 World Cups.

Samuel Moutoussamy (DR Congo): Moutoussamy was born in France to a Congolese mother and Indo-Guadeloupean father of Tamil origin. Indo-Guadeloupeans are mostly descendants of indentured workers who came mostly from South India in the late 19th century.

Under FIFA rules, a player is eligible to play for a national team if a biological mother, biological father, or grandparent was born on that country's territory. The player should also hold the passport of the country he is representing. The 29-year-old midfielder is currently playing for Greek Super League club Atromitos and has earned 57 DR Congo senior national team caps after making his debut in 2019.

He earlier played for FC Nantes in France and Turkish side Ozbelsan Sivasspor.

Nishan Velupillay (Australia): Born in Melbourne to an Anglo-Indian mother and a Malaysian father of Sri Lankan Tamil descent, the 25-year-old winger is one of 17 players in the Socceroos' 26-member squad who will be making their FIFA World Cup debut. He plays for Melbourne Victory in the Australia top-tier A-League.

He made his Australia debut in October 2024 during the 2026 World Cup qualification round, scoring in his maiden appearance as a substitute against China.

Since then, Nishan has gone on to collect seven more senior caps for Australia. He has scored thrice, all of them in the World Cup qualifiers.

He grew up in Melbourne and attended Mazenod College in Mulgrave. He began his football journey in the youth ranks at Glen Eira FC and worked his way into the Melbourne Victory academy.

Tahsin Mohammed Jamshid (Qatar): Tahsin, who turns 20 on June 16, was born in Doha to Malayali parents, who moved to Qatar from Kannur in 2006.

Tahsin got into football under his father Jamshid's guidance, who was a former University of Calicut player. Jamshid, currently an accountant in Qatar, hails from Thalassery and mother Shyma from Valapattanam, near Kannur.

Tahsin honed his footballing skills at the Aspire Academy in Doha, becoming the first Indian-origin player to feature in the Qatar Stars League, the top-tier competition of the country. He currently plays for Al Duhail SC.

Tahsin, a winger, made his international debut against Afghanistan in 2024 during the Asian qualifiers group match of the 2026 FIFA WC.

(PTT)

India set for New Zealand cricket series

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Auckland

India will tour New Zealand for a marathon all-format series from October 22 to December 1 this year, featuring an unprecedented 10 white-ball games in what would be the biggest men's bilateral cricket series ever held in this country.

India will take on the Black Caps in five T20Is, as many ODIs and two Tests across five major centres.

The 12 matches would be the highest ever featuring a touring side in New Zealand's history. The series would be a major landmark as the two countries celebrate 100 years of sporting ties. The 40-day tour will begin with the opening T20I in Christchurch on October 22. The T20I series will be followed by the ODI leg, which will start at Eden Park in Auckland on November 4. The Test series will commence at the Cello Basin Reserve in



Wellington from November 19 to 23, while the second and final Test will be played at Hagley Oval in Christchurch from November 27 to December 1. "When it comes to cricket — it simply doesn't get bigger than India and we're determined to deliver New Zealanders a tour like no other," NZC Chief Marketing and Commercial Officer Glenn Critchley said. "This will be about more than just the cricket on the field — it will be a celebration

of New Zealand's shared history and culture with India, and our burgeoning rivalry and friendship through cricket.

"The passion and the following this team has is staggering — not to mention some of the players expected to tour such as Virat Kohli and Jasprit Bumrah — so we're bracing for the intensity and fandom that will accompany the tour," he added.

The series will mark India's first Test tour of New Zealand since the 2019-20 season.

Since then, New Zealand have visited India twice, including their historic 2024-25 tour when they completed a 3-0 sweep in the Test series.

The New Zealand Government will be supporting the India tour along-

INDIA'S TOUR OF NEW ZEALAND SCHEDULE	
1st T20I	— 22 October, Christchurch
2nd T20I	— 24 October, Christchurch
3rd T20I	— 27 October, Wellington
4th T20I	— 30 October, Auckland
5th T20I	— 1 November, Hamilton
1st ODI	— 4 November, Auckland
2nd ODI	— 7 November, Wellington
3rd ODI	— 10 November, Hamilton
4th ODI	— 13 November, Mount Maunganui
5th ODI	— 15 November, Mount Maunganui
1st Test	— 19-23 November, Wellington
2nd Test	— 27 November-1 December, Christchurch

side adjacent sporting tours by the country later in the year, as 100 years of sporting ties between New Zealand and India are commemorated. "It's always a special occasion playing India," New Zealand spinner Ish Sodhi said.

"They're an unbelievable cricket team, full of talent and star power — you know every time you face them it's going to be seriously challenging. The rivalry we've built in recent years is pretty staggering and I'm sure this tour will deliver many more big moments.

"Then there's the Indian fans and the energy and noise they bring — it really is like nothing else and something everyone should experience at least once in their life.

England seeks a fresh start at Lord's as Ashes backlash lingers

FOSTER NIUMATA ■ London

The past is fiercely protected at Lord's Cricket Ground.

The Long Room, the slope of the field, the bell before play, dress codes and honors boards.

But inside this normally comforting time capsule, England will try to escape its recent past when it begins its first home test of the year against New Zealand on Thursday.

An occasion that should herald a fresh start is enveloped by a stench of dissatisfaction lingering from England's humiliating tour to Australia.

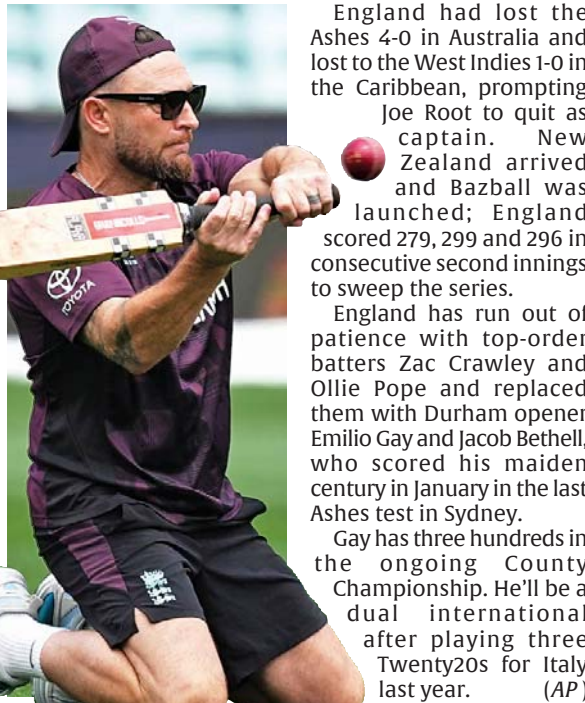
A team that was groomed for two years to end Australia's grip on the Ashes was crushed in 11 days before Christmas; tied for the quickest Ashes series defeat in 104 years. England's slack preparation and wrong tactical approach were aggravated by reports of excessive drinking under relentless local media scrutiny.

None of the leadership group paid a price. Director of cricket Rob Key, coach Brendon McCullum and captain Ben Stokes

survived a review of the Ashes tour. That didn't go down well with team supporters, and McCullum understood.

"You have got to handle a little bit of the backlash," he told the BBC.

Fixes since the Ashes include reimposing a curfew and hiring more backroom staff, including fielding



coach Sarah Taylor, the wicket-keeping great and first woman to coach an England men's test team.

Nothing banishes a putrid odor like the sweet smell of success, and England can take heart from its response to a similarly dire state in 2022 when McCullum, a former New Zealand captain, took charge.

England had lost the Ashes 4-0 in Australia and lost to the West Indies 1-0 in the Caribbean, prompting Joe Root to quit as captain. New Zealand arrived and Bazball was launched; England scored 279, 299 and 296 in consecutive second innings to sweep the series.

England has run out of patience with top-order batters Zac Crawley and Ollie Pope and replaced them with Durham opener Emilio Gay and Jacob Bethell, who scored his maiden century in January in the last Ashes test in Sydney.

Gay has three hundreds in the ongoing County Championship. He'll be a dual international after playing three Twenty20s for Italy last year. (AP)

Capsey, Knight fifties floor India in third women's T20I, England win series 2-1

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Taunton (UK)

Alice Capsey's fiery 82 and Heather Knight's composed unbeaten 70 powered England to a series-clinching six-wicket victory over India in the third and final Women's T20I here. England won the series 2-1, also giving India some points to ponder ahead of the Women's T20 World Cup where Harmanpreet Kaur and Co. will face Pakistan in their tournament opener in Birmingham on June 14.

England did the immediate task of scaling down 181 by reaching 184 for four in 18.3 overs. It was their second highest run-chase in the shortest format, built around a 137-run alliance from just 76 balls for the fourth wicket between Capsey and Knight.

But the beginning of that trip was full of turbulence as England lost openers Sophia Dunkley, Danny Wyatt-Hodge and Amy Jones within the Power Play for a mere 38 on the board. Pacer Kranti Goud, who has been recalled to the side, did the



early damage, jettisoning Hodge and Jones. Hodge's dismissal came through a lovely delivery that nipped back to rattle her stumps.

But England found stability as Capsey, who struck nine fours and three sixes in her 43-ball innings, and Knight, whose 42-ball

innings featured 10 fours, blunted Indian bowlers.

Both Capsey and Knight needed a confidence-boost after recent failures, and they did it on a must-win occasion.

They duo relied on exquisite timing and placement to ward off Indian pacers and spinners alike. Capsey raced to her fifty in 27 balls, while Knight was tad more sedate off 31 balls.

We are pretty clear about our T20 World Cup XI: Harmanpreet

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Taunton (UK)

Skipper Harmanpreet Kaur said India will use the two warm-up matches ahead of the Women's T20 World Cup to test a few more combinations and give opportunities to players such as Radha Yadav and Bharti Fulmali.

India arrived in England hoping to end their long wait for a maiden Women's T20 World Cup title. However, their build-up to the ICC showpiece suffered a setback after hosts England came from behind to clinch the three-match T20I series 2-1.

After registering a 38-run victory in the opener, India slipped to a 26-run defeat before losing the decider by six wickets on Tuesday.

"I feel we are pretty much clear, like what our XI is going to be going forward. I think we are pretty much



clear and still we have two more games, practice games before the World Cup where we can still think about the other combinations," she said after the loss.

"Like Radha is there. She did really well in WPL and she also feels ready. And apart from her, Bharti Fulmali is also there. She is a middle-order batter. She also batted really well.

"I think still we have two very good players who are sitting out and hopefully we will give them a fair chance in the practice games where we can see how they go about," Harmanpreet added.

India have already experimented with their batting order following the return of Yastika Bhatia from a lengthy injury layoff.

We were not able to build pressure with dot balls, can't repeat the mistake in WC: Mandhana



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Taunton (UK)

Vice-captain Smriti Mandhana pinned India's six-wicket defeat against England in the third T20I to their failure to bowl enough dot balls, and hoped not to repeat the mistake in the upcoming Women's T20 World Cup. England dented India's build-up for the ICC showpiece, registering a come-from-behind 2-1 win in the three-match series.

"We definitely started extremely well with the ball, (reducing England to) 35 for 3. I wouldn't really take anything away from the partnership they had. I think they played really good cricketing shots," Mandhana said at the post-match press conference.

After an early wobble, England recovered through a 137-run alliance for the fourth wicket between Alice Capsey (82) and Heather Knight (70 not out) to chase down the target of 181.

"In hindsight, we would have been able to build pressure with a few dot balls, but we were not able to do that. We will definitely look at this game in a way where we can do better and not repeat these mistakes in the World Cup coming ahead," she added.

India drub Chinese Taipei 13-1 to enter semifinals of U-18 men's Asia Cup hockey

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kakamigahara (Japan)

The Indian men's hockey team produced a clinical display, thrashing Chinese Taipei 13-1 in its last Pool A match to storm into the semifinals of the U-18 Asia Cup 2026 here on Wednesday.

India ended their pool engagements with wins against Kazakhstan, Korea and Chinese Taipei, while losing to hosts Japan. It gave them nine points from four matches.



The team's attacking prowess was on full display against Chinese Taipei, with Ashish Tani Purti emerging as the standout performer with a hat-trick (27th, 35th, 42nd minutes), while Gazee Khan (40th, 44th), Siddharth Ben (30th, 52nd) and Rahul Yadav (20th, 54th) scored a brace each.

Karan Gautam (7th), Premchand Soy (11th), captain Ketan Kushwaha (13th) and Varinder Singh (50th) also contributed to the tally.

India made their intentions clear from the outset, dictating the tempo

with incisive play that constantly troubled the Chinese Taipei defence. They broke the deadlock in the seventh minute as Karan converted India's first penalty corner of the match.

Premchand then doubled the lead with a field goal, while skipper Kushwaha added a third in quick succession to put his side firmly in control by the end of the first quarter.

India continued their dominance in the second quarter. Yadav added a fourth before Purti converted a penalty corner to make it 5-0.

Harsh Dubey looks forward to rubbing shoulders with Kohli, Rohit and Gill

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Sharing the ODI dressing room with Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma would be quite an "achievement" for rookie Indian all-rounder Harsh Dubey who is also looking forward to understand Test captain Shubman Gill's leadership style in the upcoming home series against Afghanistan.

The 23-year-old Dubey has been picked in both the Test and ODI squads and the left-arm spinner said everything has felt like a dream since he was informed of his maiden national call-up. Speaking to "JioStar", Dubey recalled the moment he found out about his selection in the Indian squad for the Afghanistan series, which begins with a one-off Test in Mulanpur from June 6.



Nathan Ellis shines as Australia beat Pakistan

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Lahore

Fast bowler Nathan Ellis grabbed a career-best 4-33 on yet another tricky wicket and led Australia to series-leveling 41-run win over Pakistan in the second one-day international.

Pakistan, which won the first game by five wickets on a turning wicket, was bowled out for 190 after Australia had scored 231-9 on a pitch that had plenty of turn for the spinners and variable bounce for the seam bowlers.

"It's definitely different to the traditional one-day cricket we see around the world at the moment," Ellis said in reference to Pakistan's ploy to make rank-turners for the series against an understrength Australia.

"It's no secret that today it was pretty low and slow all, we saw the cutters and the slow balls working a lot today, and the ball started to tail and reverse swing through the 35-to-45-over mark."



Half-centuries from captain Josh Inglis (51) and Cameron Green (53) were supported by Matthew Renshaw's run-a-ball 43, while 19-year-old Oliver Peake added 31 off 32 balls after Pakistan captain Shaheen Shah Afridi won the toss and elected to field.

Left-arm spinner Arafat Minhas, who became the first Pakistani bowler to take five wickets in his debut ODI at Rawalpindi last

Saturday, returned figures of 2-27.

Leg-spinner Abrar Ahmed had 2-34 while the pace duo of captain Afridi (3-36) and Haris Rauf (2-49) shared five wickets between them.

All-rounder Shadab Khan scored 71 off 104 balls to make amends for his wicketless return of 0-56 and took the Pakistan chase deep before he was the last man dismissed — stumped down the legside by Inglis off leg-spinner Tanveer Sangha.

Afghanistan skipper carries a nation's red-ball hopes

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ Mullanpur

When Afghanistan take on India in a one-off Test beginning Saturday, Hashmatullah Shahidi will be more than just the captain of the visiting cricket team. The 31-year-old would also be the batting fulcrum around whom Afghanistan's Test ambitions revolve.

In the absence of veterans Rashid Khan and Mohammad Nabi, the soft-spoken left-hander will shoulder the responsibility of proving that Afghanistan's red-ball aspirations are no longer dependent on a handful of superstar names.

It is a role that would have made his father proud. Shahidi's father, a physics teacher and author of multiple textbooks, values education above everything else.



Like many Afghan families affected by years of conflict and political turmoil, the Shahidis spent time in Pakistan before returning home, and cricket was hardly the most secure career path for a young boy growing up amid uncertainty. Yet the son of a teacher worked his way up to emerge as one of Afghanistan's most important cricketing minds.